



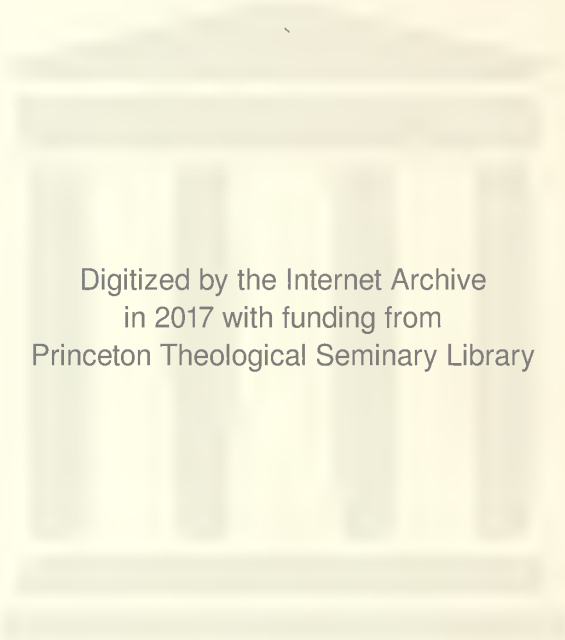
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Dr. Van Mastricht,

ON

REGENERATION.

Dr. W. M. W.

110

NOT A S. M. W.

TREATISE

ON

REGENERATION.

By PETER VAN MASTRICHT, *D.D.*
Professor of Divinity in the Universities of FRANKFORT,
DUISBURGH, and UTRECHT.

Extracted from his System of Divinity, called Theologia theoretico-practica; and faithfully translated into English; With an APPENDIX, containing Extracts from many celebrated Divines of the reformed Church, upon the same Subject.

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GREEN, in the Old-Council-Chamber.

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P R E F A C E.

THE reader will perhaps be desirous to know, who this Doct. *Van Mastricht* is, and what the particular reasons are, for publishing the following Treatise at this time. The Publisher will endeavour, in brief to satisfy the reader in both.

Peter Van Mastricht, author of the following Treatise ; was born in the year 1630, in the city of *Cologne*, in *Germany*, of honorable parentage, many of whose ancestors had been considerable sufferers in the protestant cause. He was educated in the university of *Utrecht* ; was several years a preacher, in various parts of *Germany* and *Denmark* ; was invited to settle in *Copenhagen*, capital of the latter : But was prevailed upon by the *Elect*or of *Brandenburg*, (grand-father, or great-grand-father to the present king of *Prussia*) to accept the place of professor of Hebrew and practical divinity, in his new established university at *Frankfort*. He afterwards served in the same station at *Duisburg*, near his native place ; and the last thirty years of his life, he sustained the same office in the famous university of *Utrecht*, the place of his education. He was greatly esteem'd as a most accurate, judicious, learned and pious divine. He died in this office near eighty years of age. His system of divinity, from whence the following Treatise is extracted, is the product of a long life, spent in the study, practice and instruction of divinity.

The reason for translating and publishing the following Treatise at this time, is principally a hope, that it may have a tendency to put a stop to the controversy, which seems to be growing among us, relative to regeneration,

neration ; Whether it be wrought by the immediate influences of the divine Spirit, or by light as the means ? and happily to unite us in the truth. The translator is encouraged thus to hope, from the following considerations,

1. He hath frequently heard gentlemen, who maintain opposite sides of this question, manifest their entire approbation of, and concurrence with *Van Mastricht* ; which induces him to think, that with many, the controversy is more about terms than any thing else ; and that when they find, they both can agree with *Van Mastricht*, they will be lead so to explain themselves, as to agree with each other.

2. As our Author cannot be looked upon as partial in favour of any particular system of doctrines prevailing amongst us ; 'tis hoped and expected that all will read him without prejudice or partiality.

3. The great character which our author sustains, for which we have the ample testimony of Dr. *Cotton Mather*, (whose name hath always been much respected in the churches of *New-England*) in the following words, †
 “ There is nothing that I can with so much plerophoric recommend unto you, as a *Mastricht*, his *Theologia theoretico-practica*. That a minister of the gospel may be thoroughly furnished unto every good work, and in one or two quarto volumes enjoy a well furnished library ; I know not that the sun has ever shone upon an human composure that is equal to it ; and I can heartily subscribe unto the commendation which *Pontanus*, in his *Laudatio Funebri* upon the author has given of it. *De hoc opere confidenter affirmo, quod eo ordine sit digestum, tanto rerum pondere prægnans et tumidum, tanta et tam varia eruditione refertum ; ut nescio an in illo genere usquam Gentium exstet aliquid magis accuratum et elaboratum.*

† Dr. Mather's directions for a Candidate of the ministry. P. 35.

“ *boratum*. † I hope you will, next unto the sacred
 “ scriptures, make a *Mastricht* the storehouse to which
 “ you may resort continually. But above all things re-
 “ member the dying words of this true Divine ; which
 “ he uttered *altissima voce* (with a loud voice, and I wish
 “ all that study divinity might hear it !) *Se nullo loco et*
 “ *numero habere veritatis defensionem, quam sincera pietas*
 “ *et vitæ sanctitas, individuo nexu non comitetur.*” * The
 character, I say, of our Author, and his professedly de-
 livering upon this point the general sentiment of the
 whole reformed church abroad, it is hoped, will weigh
 so much, in the mind of every one, as to obtain a candid
 examination of his sentiments, before they reject them.

4. Our Author’s arguments are exceeding plain,
 scriptural, and convictive. There is nothing liable to
 the imputation of metaphysical nicety and subtilty. So
 far from it that his Contemporaries, who opposed his
 doctrines, “ accused him of not allowing reason its pro-
 per place ; but of dethroning it thro’ pretence of religi-
 on.” ’Tis therefore to be hoped, that many who have
 opposed the sentiments which our Author maintains,
 from a notion of their being metaphysical subtilties, will
 by his plain, scriptural arguments, be convinced of the
 truth of them.

5. Many, ’tis to be feared, are prejudiced against the
 doctrine which our Author endeavours to establish in
 the following Treatise, from a notion that it is *new* and
 unheard of in the Christian Church. The following
 Treatise,

† In English thus. Of this work (i. e. his system of divinity) I
 confidently affirm, that it is disposed in that order, abounds in such
 weighty matter, and is filled with such a copious variety of learning,
 that I know not whether the world can afford any thing of the kind
 better studied, and more accurate than this.

* That he hath no opinion of any defence of the truth, which
 sincere piety and holiness of life doth not inseparably accompany.

Treatise, it is hoped, will entirely remove this groundless objection.

But if this little Treatise should not prove so successful, as to reconcile our differences upon this point, it will at least serve this purpose, to enable those, who have not opportunity, to look into antient authors on this subject, to judge in some measure what the sentiments of the Reformed Church have been upon this important point.

These considerations induce the Translator strongly to hope, that this publication may be of happy service, at the present day. Should it in any measure contribute to the promoting and maintaining of truth, the Translator will think himself amply rewarded for his trouble.

The Translator begs the candour of the Reader, with regard to the many inelegancies of stile, which, he is apprehensive, the critical reader will discover in the following pages. Our Author's manner of writing is laconic, with very little decoration or ornament. A translation, in any measure literal, must resemble the genius of the original : And many Idioms of the original language will be apt insensibly to slide into the translation. The Translator had rather forego any ornaments of stile, which the work might receive from a more free translation, than thereby endanger himself to misrepresent the sense of our Author. He hopes the Translation justly represents the Author's sentiments, which he looks upon the principal thing ; and therefore persuades himself, that any little inaccuracies of expression, will be kindly overlooked by the benevolent reader.



ON REGENERATION.

J O H N iii. 5.

Verily, verily I say unto thee, except a man be born of Water, and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the Kingdom of God.

I. **H**AVING in a former treatise discoursed upon the *first* act of application, in which the holy Spirit *offers* to those who are to be saved, for their reception, the Redeemer and Redemption. I come now to discourse upon the *second*, in which he *bestows* upon them that *power*, by which they are *enabled* to receive the offered benefits; which is done by *regeneration*, the necessity of which our Saviour holds forth in the words above mentioned.

The second act of application is regeneration.

THE EXPLANATORY PART.

II. These words contain a weighty, powerful assertion of our Saviour, concerning the *necessity of regeneration*. In which we may note;

The text explained.

1. *The person asserting.* I say unto you; I whom just now you saluted by the title of *Rabbi*, or Master, a master *sent from God*, of which you have been con-

B

vinced

^a Ver. 2. vinced by so many miracles ; ^a I, who am the *Amen*,
^b Isa. 65. 16. or the God of truth ; ^b yea, the *truth* itself, ^c which
^c John 14. 6. cannot either deceive or be deceived ; ^d whom there-
^d Titus 1. 2. fore you may safely believe, *do assert, testify and declare*
^e Heb. 6. 18. unto you, and not only to you, but to the whole na-
^f John 8. 14. tion ; yea, and to all generations which shall exist in
^f John 3. 7. future ages. ^f

2. *The manner of assertion, amen, amen, verily, verily.*
 The word *amen* is of Hebrew derivation, from the root, *aman* (to be stable or firm) which is retained in the Greek, Syriac, Arabic, and all the Latin versions ; and also in the vulgar languages. It is an adverb of *asserting* ; that is *verily, certainly*, or the thing is so, or this is the *truth*. Aquila renders it, by *faithfully* ; the Seventy by, *so be it*, but sometimes retain the word *amen*. It is used either to *confirm* what hath been already spoken, ^g or to *affirm* what is now to be said. The first use is most frequent in the old testament, the latter in the new. It is a particle used for confirmation, and is rendered either by *verily* or *so be it* : in the first sense it is used in confirmation of something *affirmed*, in the latter, in confirmation of something *wished or desired*. If the sentence be an *informative assertion*, the word means *verily or truly* ; but if *optative* or *intreative*, the meaning is, *so be it*. The particle *nai* comprehends both significations ; as it is sometimes *assertory*, sometimes expressive of vehement desire. Hence Luke useth the word *nai* (yea) for *amen*.
^h 2 Cor. 1. 17. *men*. The apostle Paul connects them together, ^h *yea and amen* ; that one might emphatically explain the other. Our Saviour repeats the word *amen* (verily) perhaps in different senses, so that the *first* may signify himself, I the *amen*, the *God of truth* ; ⁱ as it is said
ⁱ If. 65. 16. these things saith the *Amen, the faithful & true Witness*.
^k Rev. 3: 14. The *latter* may signify the truth of the thing asserted. So that the meaning of the expression may be this, I the God of *truth* declare the *truth* unto you. It may also

also be designed to confirm and strengthen the truth of his paradox concerning the absolute necessity of regeneration, and the more powerfully to beget in Nicodemus a belief of the doctrine; I, the Master sent from God, verily say unto you, and that repeatedly. There are some who think the repetition of the word denotes, not a simple affirmation; but an *oath*, and that it is the same in sense with the expression, *as I live saith the Lord*, in the old testament, as the Chaldee version, for this expression, *hath, as I am constant*; stable, firm, or as I am the *amen*, the God of truth. But it doth not appear to me consistent, that one who so severely censures a rash oath, ¹ should so frequently ¹ Mat. 5. 33, swear himself; for it is said that this expression is ³⁴ used fifty times by our Saviour. However, we may at least consider it as a *forcible* manner of expression, or as the Hebrews say, as a *corroboration of his words*, admirably suited to this paradox of the absolute necessity of regeneration.

3. The thing *asserted*, with regard to which we may note,

(1) The subject, *regeneration*, or the new-birth, "*except a man be born*," the same thing in ver. 2, is expressed by being born *again*, or *from above*. The word *anotken* rendered *again*, signifies sometimes, *again*, or the *second* time; thus Nicodemus seems to have understood it: ^m in which sense it occurs, Gal. ^m Ver. 4.

4. 9. And thus Syrus and Nonnus render it in this place. The apostle Peter useth the word *anagenethenai* to be born again. ⁿ In other places the word signifies *from above*, or *from heaven*. ^o Which it seems our Saviour designed to intimate, by explaining the word *anotken* used in verse 3, by the expression *of water and of the spirit*, in verse 5, or to be born spiritually and from above, that is from heaven. What if we should connect these two senses together, as one is subordinate to the other: so that to be born *anotken* signifies both

ⁿ 1 Pet. 1. 3, 23.

^o Ver. 31. Joh.

19. 11. James

1. 17. and 3.

17.

to be born *from above*, that is spiritually, and from heaven ; and also *again*, or the second time ? since that being born, which is from above, or of the Spirit, is a second birth, as it follows the first and natural birth, which is after the flesh. “*Except a man be born again,*” our Saviour calleth it a *birth or being born*, to denote the *universal* amendment or renovation of man thereby : he intimates the necessity of a renovation, not of this or that particular part or faculty, but a total renovation of the whole man, which is a new or second birth, whereby he becomes a *new man*, a *new creature*, and walks in *newness of life*.^P Of which more under the *doctrinal* part.

2 Cor. 5. 17.

Gal. 6. 15.

Rev. 21. 5.

(2) The origin of regeneration, “*of water and the spirit.*” The particle *ek* rendered *of*, as is plain from the subject, denotes in this place, not the *material*, but the *efficient* cause, as it doth in many other places ;² since neither water nor spirit are the matter out of which a spiritual regeneration is effected. *Water and spirit*, some consider as two different things ; so that by *water* they understand the *instrumental*, and by *spirit*, the *principal* cause, because (as they suppose) the spirit, by water, effects regeneration. But they who are of this opinion are divided ; some by water understand the Jewish baptisms or washings, with which the Jews, more especially the Pharisees, were wont to wash their proselytes, before their admission into the Jewish church ; likewise their own hands, clothes, meat and even their bodies, of which mention is made in various places of the new testament ;³ to these, our Nicodemus, as he was a Pharisee, must have been accustomed. Others by *water* here, understand the sacramental water of *baptism*, by which they suppose the Spirit effects regeneration. And here again some suppose the baptismal water to be *directly* intended, as most of the Fathers ; others, only by way of allusion. Others more rightly understand but one thing expressed,

Mark 7. 8.

Heb. 9. 10.

Mark 7. 4.

fed by two terms, as the *water* of the Spirit, or spiritual water, or rather the *Spirit* having the properties of water, which like water cleanse in regeneration. For our Saviour doth not mean to lead Nicodemus to receive the sacrament of baptism, (which at that time was not instituted, at least as an ordinary, universal sacrament;) but to seek the regeneration of the Holy Ghost. "He saved us by the washing of regeneration:" wherefore in the continuation of this discourse, our Saviour makes no further mention of water, but only of the *Spirit*. I need not observe that by *Spirit* here, is to be understood the third person in the sacred Trinity, with relation to the work of spiritual purification, which is effected by regeneration and renovation. * Tit. 3. 5.
* Ver. 6, 7, 8.
* Tit. 3. 5.

(3) The necessity of this regeneration, with regard to which, may be observed,

[1] The manner in which both the necessity, and universality of it are expressed, "*except a man be born.*" A man, that is, every man, which extends the necessity to all and every one, so that not one individual can be excepted from this necessity. However less is expressed by this form of speech, than is intended. It means not only that *no one* can be saved without this regeneration; but that *all* the regenerate shall be saved. Not that regeneration (at least in it's limited sense) is the only thing required unto salvation; since besides this, *conversion*, sanctification, &c. are necessary, in which the *power*, bestowed in regeneration, may be drawn forth into the actual exercises of faith and repentance: but that all and every one, who is regenerated, will also be brought to *conversion*, sanctification, faith and repentance, and so to salvation.

[2] The use, or the purpose to which regeneration is subservient, viz. "*entering into the kingdom of God.*" The kingdom of God here signifies both the kingdom of grace upon earth, or the church, that the person regenerated may become a true and living member thereof; * Mat. 4. 17.
Col. 4. 11.

* Luke 14 15. thereof; and also the kingdom of *glory* in heaven; *
and 23. 42. with all things which pertain to both these kingdoms, *
* Luke 8. 10. i. e. all spiritual blessings.

[3] The *possession* and enjoyment of this kingdom.
“He cannot enter therein. Ver. 3. “He cannot see the kingdom of God.” Here regeneration is extended to the power, “he cannot,” the reason of which is given in the following verse, “That, which is born of the flesh, that is by natural generation, is flesh, or carnal, defiled with sin; and that, which is born of the spirit, is spirit, or spiritual and saving. For regeneration, strictly so cal-

* Eph. 2. 2. 5. ed, finds man spiritually dead, * into whom it infuseth the first act, or principle of the spiritual life; by which he hath a power or ability to perform spiritual exercises. Therefore, without this, he can neither see the kingdom of God, that is *mentally*, as he is blind, “He perceiveth not the things of the spirit of God: for they are foolishness unto him, neither can he know them, because they
* 1 Cor. 2 14. are spiritually discerned.” * Nor if he could see, could he enter into the kingdom of God, as “he is not subject to
* Rom. 8. 7. the law of God,” neither indeed can be; * who also “of
* 2 Cor. 3. 5. himself is not sufficient to think any thing spiritually good.” *
Who therefore stands in absolute need of *illumination* by regeneration, in order to his seeing the kingdom of heaven, and of a *renovation* of his will, in order to his willing to enter into it. Which power is afterwards excited in the exercises of faith and repentance, in conversion and sanctification, whereby he sees the kingdom of God, and at the same time enters into the same.

That besides the external call, regeneration is also necessary to the application of redemption, which is proved by the scriptures,

THE DOCTRINAL PART.

III. It is not sufficient to the application of redemption, or a participation therein, that the Redeemer and the redemption purchased by him, be offered, by the external call of the gospel, to those who are to be saved; for their reception, unless that power be bestowed upon them, by regeneration, by which they

they may be enabled to receive the offered benefits. For the Redeemer himself expressly denies that any one, without regeneration, *can* either see spiritual objects, or approach them, by entering into the kingdom of God. Hence faith, by which alone Christ is applied to us, and we made partakers of his redemption, is ascribed only to those who are *born of God*. * John 1. 12, 13

And the apostle is even more express than this, who, after that he had taught that the *kindness of God our Saviour had appeared unto men*, viz. By the external call of the gospel, adds, that he saved them, that is applied to them the *kindness* or redemption of the Saviour, by the washing of *regeneration*, and the *renewing of the Holy Ghost*. † The same thing is held forth in all those texts of scripture, which ascribe our partaking of Christ's redemption, or our salvation, (1) In express terms to *regeneration*, and the *renewing of the Holy Ghost* : ‡ (2) To *circumcision of the heart* : § (3) to the *taking away* of the heart of stone, and the *putting with-* in us a heart of flesh, the giving of a *new heart* and a *new spirit*. ¶ (4) To the creation of a *pure heart*. † (5) To *spiritual drawing* ; † unless you would choose to refer that to the grace of conversion. (6) To the *illumination* of the mind, † and *renewing* of the will. † (7) To a *spiritual resurrection* and *quicken- ing*. * All which expressions are synonymous with regeneration, signifying the same thing in different terms.

IV. The foundation of this necessity lieth in the *universal, spiritual death* of all the elect, by which they, as well as reprobates, are by nature *dead* in sin ; † have an heart of *stone* ; † an *uncircumcised* heart ; † are blind in their *minds* ; † have their *wills* alienated from God, from the life of God, and from all spiritual and saving good ; † and are therefore utterly insufficient to think even the least good thought ; † and consequently also to receive, by a living faith, the Redeemer offered to them in the gospel, and the necessary terms of salvation ;

tion; unless, by regeneration, *power* be bestowed upon them in a new spiritual life by the Holy Ghost. However a man spiritually dead can bear spiritual truths, he can also, *grammatically* at least, *understand* what he hears; he can moreover approve in his judgment, at least *speculatively*, what he understands, and lastly he can in a general manner have some kind of *affection* towards what he approves. Nor doth the holy Spirit in the work of regeneration and spiritual quickening, treat with the elect, as with *stocks* or brutes; but as *rational* creatures, to whose reception, the Redeemer, with the terms of salvation, have been already offered by the external call; to the reception of which, the Spirit hath *invited* them by the most pressing motives. Yea it is possible that persons, as yet spiritually dead, may, if not by the powers which they are *naturally* possessed of; yet by the assistance of common grace, arrive to certain attainments, not accompanying salvation; * or that are not inseparably connected therewith. So that we are not to think; there is nothing to be done with the unregenerate. However, while they perform *all* these things, they do *nothing* at all, which is *spiritual*, or before nothing in a *spiritual manner*. *

▼ Heb. 6. 4. 5.
6. 9.

* 1 Cor. 2. 13,
14.
The meaning
of the word
regeneration.

V. That we may attain to a more clear understanding of the *nature* of this regeneration, so necessary to salvation: we must carefully observe with regard to the *word*, that both the scriptures, and also divines use it, sometimes in a *larger* sense, to denote the *whole* operation of the Holy Ghost upon the souls of those who are to be saved; whereby they are brought into a state of grace; so that, besides the external call, it comprehends conversion, and even initial sanctification: In which sense practical divines lay down the *marks*, motives, and means of regeneration: Sometimes the word regeneration is used in a more *limited* sense, as distinguished from the external call, from conversion,

conversion and from sanctification: So that the *external call* signifies only the *offer* of redemption for our reception: *Regeneration* conveys that *power* into the soul, by which the person, who is to be saved, is *enabled* to receive the offer: *Conversion* puts forth the power received into *actual* exercise, so that the soul doth *actually* receive the offered benefits: Sanctification brings forth the fruits of conversion, or of faith and repentance, in a carefulness to maintain good works; yet not so immediately, but that an union with Christ and justification come between conversion, and sanctification, at least in the order of nature, if not of time. It is in this *stricter* sense of the word, we shall consider the doctrine of regeneration at present. In which sense it means the same with *circumcision* of the heart, with *taking away* the heart of stone, and *putting* within us a heart of *flesh*, with a new *creation*, with *drawing*, with *illumination*, with *turning* the will, and especially with a spiritual *resurrection* and *quickenings*, of which we have already spoken in sect. III. The terms used in Greek for regeneration are, *anakainosis*,^a *agiasmós pneu-*
matos,^b *kainee ktísis*,^c *paliggenesia*,^d *anagenesis*.^e Thus regeneration, in the proper sense of the word, is only a *second* and spiritual *generation*, in which the *soul* receives its *spiritual life*, as the body receives its *natural life* from the first generation. The *father* in this case is God; hence we are said to be *born* of God,^f and the regenerate are called the *sons of God*.^g The *mother* in whose womb as it were we are conceived and nourished, is the church.^h The *seed*, the word of God, which *liveth* and *abideth* forever;ⁱ received by the external call of the gospel. From all which considerations, since a *divine nature* is communicated to the regenerate, similar in its kind to the holiness of the Deity, it is with sufficient propriety called a generation, as that is only a communication of life, with a resemblance to the Father begetting.

Expressions
synonymous
with regenera-
tion.

^a 1 Tim. 3. 5.

^b 2 Thes. 2. 13.

^c 2 Cor. 5. 17.

^d Mat. 19. 28.

^e 1 Pet. 1. 3. 23.

^f John 1. 12.

^g 1 Joh. 5. 18.

^h Gal. 4. 26.

ⁱ 1 Pet. 1. 23.

What the thing is, intended by regeneration.

VI. As to the *thing* intended by regeneration; it is only that *physical* † operation of the Holy Ghost, whereby he begets in men who are elected, redeemed

and

† The word, *physical*, which is frequently used by our author, is offensive to some gentlemen, who seem not to reject the thing intended by it: their dislike thereto seems to arise from an apprehension that it implies the bestowment of a new natural faculty, such as the understanding, will, or affections: but this 'tis evident is not our author's meaning, and perhaps not the meaning of any, who use the term. They do not suppose the regenerate to exercise any natural faculty which the unregenerate do not. They use the word simply in opposition to *moral*. Now a *moral* operation is the effecting of something by moral suasion or by the laying of arguments and inducements before the mind: but these, however great and strong, attended with never so much light in the understanding, our author supposes, will not effect regeneration: but supposes there is a positive, immediate act of the divine spirit upon the soul, infusing a new principle of spiritual and divine life; whereby the soul is enabled, or qualified to exercise its natural powers and faculties in a spiritual manner. Some have chosen to express themselves hereupon in this form, viz. That God in regeneration acts after the manner of a physical cause, as Dr. Ames, Rutherford, &c. and the same thing, I take it, is intended by our English Divines when they call that operation, which regenerates, *supernatural*. They certainly use this word in opposition to *moral*, or any operation by moral suasion, or the laying of arguments and motives before the mind. See extracts from Ridgely, Willard, &c. in the appendix. --- Indeed, 'till of late, scarce any, but Pelagians, denied what is intended by a physical operation in regeneration, and the word *physical* has generally been made use of; tho' some have restricted the physical operation of the spirit in regeneration to the understanding, as most of the *Arminians*, and some of the *reformed*, who have held to regeneration by an illumination of the understanding; they seem to have been influenced to this restriction, thro' fear, least, if they extended the *physical* operation to the *will*, the freedom of man's will could not be maintained. But, tho' the generality of the reformed call the regenerating act of God a physical operation; yet I no where find, that they call the *change*, that is wrought in man thereby, a *physical change*. The immediate term or effect of regeneration according to Van Mastricht is, (§ x. xi. xii.) *grace*, spiritual life, &c. which is a moral change in the man, or a change of the moral state of his mind; tho' wrought by a physical operation. Nor is there any thing absurd in this, that the operation should be *physical*; and yet the effect *moral*: for none would suppose it beyond the power of God, (if he is pleased to exercise

exercise

and externally called, the *first act* or the principle of spiritual life, by which they are enabled to receive the offered Redeemer, and comply with the conditions of salvation. From this description may come into consideration,

VII. First. The *Author* of regeneration, which is God absolutely considered; ^k that *Father of Lights*, from whom cometh down every *good and perfect gift*; ^l because regeneration is a transient act, common to the whole Trinity; hence in the œconomy of redemption, it is attributed, (1) To the Father, as most agreeable to the character of a *father* which he sustains, ^m *from whom all the family in heaven and earth is named*, who therefore as he begat his *own Son*, so he also begets us; so that he is both his and our Father. ^o A-

The Author of regeneration.

^k John 1. 13.

Eph. 2. 5.

^l Jam. 1. 17, 18

^m 1 Pet. 1. 3.

ⁿ Jam. 1. 17, 18.

ⁿ Eph. 3. 15.

^o John 20. 17.

gain, exercise it) to determine the will of man to some particular volition, or he will, than by arguments or motives; (this is beside a possible case) here the operation would be *physical*, and yet the effect *moral*. So that the supposition of a *physical* operation, and yet a *moral* change as the effect of it, is not inconsistent in itself. And that this is actually the case, we trust our author hath sufficiently proved. The word *principle* which is here used for the immediate effect of this physical operation, and which is frequently used in this translation, has likewise given offence to some, as being a thing entirely unintelligible, a strange *something*, or a sort of *substratum* in the soul, which lies beyond the reach of human knowledge. 'Tis confessed it cannot be explained otherwise than by its consequences or effects. And is not the soul an *unknown* substratum of cogitation, whose existence can be known only by its operations? and what are the *faculties* of the soul, the *understanding*, *will* and *affections*, but *unknown* substrata of their several exercises? and what is matter but an *unknown* substratum of extension, solidity, &c. and what are all habits, but *unknown* substrata of their exercises? these substrata are unknown as to the nature of them. Their existence is known only by the qualities or actions they support. But who will disbelieve their existence, because they cannot fully comprehend the abstract nature of them? the implantation of a principle or substratum of holy exercises in regeneration is argued and known from its exercises, and operations. And we can tell the nature of it, as well as we can the nature of matter, of the soul, the faculties of the soul, and the like. And when these latter are explained, we shall think ourselves obliged to explain the former, or disbelieve its existence; but not before.

gain, (2) Regeneration is ascribed to the *Son*, as the
 P 1 Pet. 1. 2, 3. meritorious cause; ^p who for this reason is stiled a *quick-*
 1 Cor. 15. 45. *ening spirit*, ^q and the life, which we live, we are said
 Gal. 2. 20. compared with Phil. 1. to live by the faith of the *Son* of God. ^r And (3) To
 21. Col. 3. 4. the Holy Ghost; ^s hence he is stiled the *spirit of life*; ^t
 John 14. 6. because the Holy Spirit by his operation *immediately*
 1 John 3. 3. 5. effects regeneration: and the spiritual life is with pe-
 Tit. 3. 5. culiar propriety ascribed to the *spirit of life*. The
 Rom. 8. 2. 10. moving cause is merely God's great love, ^u his abundant
 Eph. 2. 5. 6. mercy; ^w his gracious good pleasure. ^x Nor is there, espe-
 1 Pet. 1. 2, 3. cially before regeneration, (while we are the children
 Tit. 3. 5. of wrath, dead in sin ^y) any thing in us which can in
 Jam. 1. 17. the least merit such a favour. The *instrument* of rege-
 Eph. 2. 1, 5. neration, (but that merely of a moral kind) is the word
 of God, ^b previously offered and received in the ex-
 1 Pet. 1. 23. ternal call of the gospel, as we have already observed.

VIII. Secondly, we may consider the *subjects* of rege-
 The subjects of regenera- tion.
 neration, which are, (1) *Men*, who are endowed with
 understanding and will, to whom, agreeably to their
 rational nature, the Spirit hath previously offered re-
 demption for their reception; with whom therefore,
 he is pleased to treat, not as with stocks or brutes, as
 we have already observed. (2) They are the *elect*; ^c
 1 Pet. 1. 2, 3. & chap. 2. 9. for regeneration is not a common gift; but a gift pro-
 ceeding from the most *distinguishing* or special grace, as
 Eph. 2. 5. it flows from God's great love, ^u from his abundant
 1 Pet. 1. 2, 3. mercy. ^d (3) They are *redeemed*; hence Peter speaks
 of regeneration, as peculiar to those, who are *sprinkled*
 1 Pet. 1. 2, 3. with the blood of Christ. ^e Again, (4) They are such,
 Eph. 2. 1, 5, 6. who are as yet *dead in sin*: ^f for unless a man be dead,
 he cannot be made alive by regeneration. I add, (5)
 Thes. 5. 23. The *whole* man throughout, ^g is the subject of rege-
 neration; the understanding, will, affections, sensitive
 faculties, &c. that all may be quickened and renewed
 2 Cor. 5. 7. thereby. ^h As by natural generation, *all* the parts of a
 man are quickened or made alive; and as, by sin, the
 Isa. 1. 5. 6. *whole* man is become corrupt and dead. ⁱ

IX. *Thirdly*, we may consider regeneration *itself*, or the regenerating *act*. Which certainly is not a moral act, exercised in offering and inviting, as is the case with the *external call*. But it is a *physical* act powerfully infusing spiritual life into the soul: Which is proved, not only, (1) By the constant phraseology of the *scriptures*, when they speak of the *exceeding greatness of his power towards those who believe*, according to the *working of his mighty power*, or the *energy of the power of his might*; yea the same power which was exerted in raising *Christ* from the dead.^k Which expressions certainly do not bespeak a *moral* agency. Also where the *scriptures* speak of spiritual *circumcision*, of taking away the heart of stone, of putting within us a heart of flesh, of creating a new heart, of drawing, of working in us to will and to do, of a resurrection from the dead, of which we have spoken in sect. III. Do these expressions in the least favour an operation merely *moral*? But, (2) It may also be proved by the very nature of the thing, in as much as regeneration is an operation upon men spiritually *dead*, infusing life into them; ¹ but what moral operation, in teaching offering, persuading, can be rationally exercised upon a man that is *dead*? ^{20.}

The act of regeneration.

^k Eph. 1. 19,

20.

¹Eph. 2. 1. 5. 6.

X. The *term* of this physical operation, or the first and immediate *effect* of regeneration, is variously expressed in scripture. *First*, it is sometimes called *grace*,^m as *I will pour out the spirit of grace*; i. e. I will pour out *grace* by my Spirit. *Be thou strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus*; ⁿ and in other places to the like purpose. By which *grace* we do not here understand, (1) The free *kindness* of God, which is called *grace freely giving* (*gratia gratis dans*) and external *grace*; from which not only *man*, but every *creature*, receiveth whatever *good* he possesseth. By which also a man already regenerate, and possessed of spiritual power, thro' a gracious providential influence, is excited to exert in *spiritual*

The term or immediate effect of regeneration.

^{1.} Grace.
^mZach. 12. 10

ⁿ 2Tim. 2. 1.

Heb. 13. 9.

¹ Pet. 2. 19.

ritual operations, the power he hath received. But, (2) By grace we here understand the *effect* of this kindness *grace, freely given, (gratia gratis data) or internal* grace, which in the scriptures is called *charisma*, ° (the free gift.) Nor, (3) Do we understand by grace here every effect of this kindness, since all the good which every creature enjoyeth, and even the whole creation, is from the *grace* of God, and in this sense universal grace may be allowed : But we understand that grace which is contradistinguished to *nature*, and as it exists in man, to the natural powers of *free will*. Neither, (4) Do we understand hereby every effect of grace, by which one man in his kind excells another. v. g. The gift of mechanical *skill*, ° or wisdom in civil government, which may be called *common* grace, by the assistance of which, in things of a *moral* nature, a man may perform any of those things which are not (as the apostle says) *echomena soterias*, or that have not a necessary connection with eternal salvation : But, (5) By *grace*, we here understand that effect of God's kindness, or the *charisma* (free gift) by which one man hath power to perform spiritual exercises, while another hath it not ; and such exercises, indeed to which God hath promised eternal salvation ; which to use the apostle's words, do accompany salvation (*echomena soterias*.⁹) Finally in this sense, by the grace bestowed in regeneration, we understand that supernatural power, by which a man is enabled to comply with the conditions of the covenant of grace, to apprehend the Redeemer by a living *faith*, to come up to the terms of salvation, to repent of sin, to love God and the Mediator supremely, &c.

XI. Secondly, the term or immediate effect of regeneration, is more frequently called *spirit*.⁷ *That which is born of the flesh, is flesh, and that which is born of the spirit, is spirit ;*⁸ from which the regenerate are stiled *spiritual*,¹ who are *spiritually minded ;*² (*phronema tou pneumatos*;

° Rom. 12. 6.
& ch. 1. 11.
1 Cor. 1. 7.

Exod. 31. 2, 3

1 Heb. 6. 9.

2 Spirit.
7 John 3. 16.
8 Gal 5. 16,
17 18. 22.
1 Gal. 6. 1.
1 Cor. 3. 1.
2 Rom. 8. 7.

matos) who perceive the things of the spirit and spiritually discern them.^w By the word spirit here we understand not the Spirit giving; but the spirit given, that is the spirit, which the Holy Ghost bestows in regeneration, the presence of which makes the soul *spiritually* alive, as much as the presence of the animal spirit makes the body *naturally* alive.^a Hence this spirit is said to quicken or make alive,^b therefore it is stiled the spirit of life,^c because the presence of this spirit, which is *im- planted* in the soul, constitutes the *spiritual* life, and capacitates and inclines the man to *spiritual* exercises, just as the natural spirit doth to *natural* exercises. This spirit, bestowed by the Holy Ghost in regeneration, is, according to it's various exercises, stiled sometimes the *spirit of grace*, sometimes the *spirit of prayer*,^d the *spirit of faith*,^e &c. agreeably to that virtue and operation which it produces in the regenerate. So that by the spirit here we understand only that *spiritual* power, by which we are enabled to perform *spiritual* exercises in a *spiritual* manner. By *spiritual* exercises or spiritual things we mean the same as the apostle by *the things of the spirit*,^f and our Saviour, by *the business* or *the things of his Father*.^g

^a Ezek. 37. 5.^b Acts 20. 10.^c John 6. 63.^d Rom. 8. 2.^e Zach. 12. 10.^f 2 Cor. 4. 13.

compared

with Isaiah

11. 1, 2.

^g 1 Cor. 2. 14.^h Luke 2. 49.

XII. Thirdly, the term, or immediate effect of regeneration, is more clearly called *spiritual life*, in its first act (or principle,) from which God is said to quicken, together with Christ, those who are dead in sin,^h that we may be raised together with him in a spiritual manner.ⁱ From the want of which spiritual life, the unregenerate are said to be *dead* in sin, alienated from the *life of God*;^k and from the presence of which, on the other hand, we are said *to live to God*,^x to the *will* of God, and *according to God*.^l This spiritual life consisteth in a *reunion* of the divine image, or original righteousness with our souls, by which our first parents, in a state of innocence, were enabled to *live to God*, and were disposed to all spiritual exercises.^m For as

3. Life.

^h Eph. 2. 5.ⁱ Col. 3. 1.^k Eph. 4. 18.^x Gal. 2. 20.^l 1 Pet. 4. 2, 6.^m Eph. 4. 24.

the Col. 3. 10.

the *natural* life consisteth in the *union* of the soul with the body ; so the *spiritual* life consisteth in the union of original righteousness with the soul. And as a man hath power to perform all *natural* actions from the *natural* life, so from the *spiritual* life the regenerate have power to perform all *spiritual* exercises. And lastly, as in the *natural* life, are virtually contained all a man's *natural* powers, which afterwards, by organs properly disposed, come forth into action : so in this *spiritual* life, are virtually contained all those *spiritual* graces, which, by the influence of converting grace, are in due time drawn forth by degrees into actual exercise.

4 The seed of God.

2 1 John 3. 9.

XIII. Hence *fourthly*, the immediate effect of regeneration is also called the *seed* of God. ² Because in the *grace*, in the *spirit*, and in the *spiritual life*, which are bestowed upon the elect in regeneration, are contained the seeds of all those graces, which are necessary to salvation : Which, under proper circumstances, do, by the heavenly dews of converting grace, gradually, yet with absolute certainty, in due time, put forth their blossoms and fruit in *actual* exercise ; like as the seeds of vegetables buried in the earth, when watered by genial showers, shoot forth into the stalk, flowers and fruit. And, *fifthly*, this immediate effect is called a *new creature*, ^h from which the regenerate are stiled the *workmanship* of God, *created in Christ Jesus unto good works, that they might walk in them.* ⁱ Also, *sixthly*, it is called a *new heart* and a *new spirit*, ^k because thereby the whole regenerate man, and all that is his, *spirit* or understanding, *heart* or will, all are *renewed*, ^l from which there is born a *new man*. ^m Thus far concerning the general term, or the first and immediate effect of regeneration, which is the *spiritual life* in its *first* act (or principle,) which is also called by other names, as *grace*, the *spirit*, the *seed of God*, a *new creature*, &c.

5. A new creature.

^h 2 Cor. 5. 7.

Gal. 6. 17.

ⁱ Eph. 2. 10.

^k Ezek 36. 26.

^l 2 Cor. 5. 17.

¹ Thes. 5. 23.

^m Eph. 4. 23.

24. Col. 3. 10.

XIV. This spiritual life, animating and quickening the *whole* regenerate man, and all the several parts and faculties of him, hath different *names* according to those different faculties. As it takes place in the *understanding* it is called a *new spirit*,ⁿ and *spiritual light*,^o and the bestowment of it by regeneration is called *illumination*,^p and those who are illuminated are called *children of the light*; ^q are said to *walk in the light* of the Lord,^r which light begets in them the *knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ Jesus our Lord*,^s and also the *saving knowledge* of God,^t and the Mediator.^u This spiritual light of the regenerate effects, (1) The simple *understanding* or perception,^w by which they know spiritual objects, not only speculatively as true, but practically as good. (2) It affects the *judgment*, so that the regenerate judge concerning the goodness of spiritual things, not only as to the general position (*in thesi*,) what is good in a general view; but also under all the particular circumstances and connections of that truth (*in hypothesi*,) what is good and profitable for them at this very time, all circumstances considered.^x In the meantime, this saving illumination in regeneration, is to be cautiously distinguished from the illumination, which is given in the external call,^y in which spiritual light is rather held up to view, than conveyed^z into the soul; or if some degree of light be bestowed by an internal work,^b that however is either merely *speculative*, extorting only an acknowledgement and profession of the truth,^c or if it be practical also, is so only (*in thesi*) or representing only, in a general manner, the goodness of the truth acknowledged by him:^d But not (*in hypothesi*) under all the circumstances of it, so as to excite a love to the truth,^e or engage us in obedience thereto, so as to walk in it;^f but is rather holding the truth in unrighteousness.^g

XV. As this spiritual life, bestowed in regeneration, is seated in the *will*, it is stiled a *new heart*,

Regeneration of the understanding, called illumination.

ⁿ Eph. 4. 22.

^o Rom. 12. 2.

^p Eph. 5. 8.

^q Eph. 1. 18.

^r 2 Cor. 4. 6.

^s Luke 16. 18.

^t Eph. 5. 8.

^u 1 Thes. 5. 5.

^v 1sa. 2. 5.

^w 2 Cor. 4. 6.

^x Col. 3. 10.

^y John 17. 3.

^z 1sa. 53. 2.

^a 1 Cor. 2. 14.

^x Ps. 73. 23.

^y Heb. 6. 4.

^z John 1. 5.

^b Num. 24. 3. 4.

^c Ma. 7. 21. 22.

^d Rom. 2. 17—

23. ^e Mar. 13.

20, 21. Heb.

6. 4. ^f 2. Thes.

2. 19. ^g Gal. 2.

14. & ch. 3. 1.

^h Rom. 1. 18.

Regeneration of the will:

^a Psal. 51. 12. *heart*, ^h *a heart of flesh*, or a heart easily affected, ⁱ a heart
ⁱ Ezek. 36. 26. on which God hath *written his fear*, ^k by which the re-
^k Jer. 32. 39. generate *walk in his statutes*. ^l For the Holy Ghost im-
^l Heb. 8. 10. plants in the *heart* or *will*, by regeneration, a new *in-*
ⁱ Ezek. 11. 19. *clination* or propensity towards spiritual good. For
20. altho' the will hath naturally a kind of propensity to-
^m Rom. 2. 14. ward *moral* good in general, ^m and toward *external* re-
ⁿ Luke 18. ligious duties, ⁿ whereby, in duties, *with which salvation*
10, 11, 12. *is not connected*, an unregenerate person may sometimes
Phil. 3. 5. 6. perform things really wonderful : ^o Yet, their propen-
^o Mark 10. 19, sity towards spiritual and *saving* good, mankind have
20, 21. Heb. utterly lost by sin ; hence they are said to be *dead* in
6. 4. 5. sin, ^p and insufficient to think even the least thought
^p Eph 2. 1. 5. spiritually good. ^q Wherefore it is absolutely necessary,
^q 2 Cor. 3. 5. that a new *propensity* toward *spiritual* good, be restored
to the will. ^r For altho' the will doth naturally follow
^r Rom 7. 22. the *last* dictate of the practical understanding, so that,
^s 2 Thes. 3. 5. were the *understanding* but sufficiently illuminated, a
immediate renovation of the will might seem unneces-
sary ; yet this is to be admitted for truth, only when
the understanding, in its last dictate, judgeth agree-
ably to the *inclination* of the will. For that is *good*,
with reference to the will, which is agreeable to its
propensity. So that, if we should make the absurd
supposition of the *understanding's* being most clearly
enlightened, and yet the *will* not renewed, the will
would not follow the practical judgment, because in
that case the understanding would not dictate agree-
ably to its propensity. v. g. If David's understand-
ing dictated, that chastity at this very time, all cir-
cumstances considered, ought to be chosen by him,
rather than adultery ; yet whilst his understanding
dictateth not agreeably to the present *propensity* of his
will, which inclineth to adultery, the will would by
no means follow the last dictate of the understanding.
It is therefore in this spiritual propensity of the will,
that the seeds of all those graces, which are necessary

to salvation are contained : Hence the *seed* of the regenerate is said to remain in them, by reason of which they cannot *abandon* themselves to sin.^a

XVI. Nor is the *spiritual life*, in regeneration, bestowed only upon the *superior* faculties of the soul, the understanding and will : But also upon the *inferior* or sensitive faculties ; the affections, senses, and even the members of the body. Hence the apostle expressly ascribes sanctification not only to *the spirit*, by which he seems to understand the spiritual faculties, such as agree to spirits only, as the understanding and will : but also to the *soul*, (*Psuche*, properly the animal soul, from which we are called *psuchikoi*, natural or sensual, as it is rendered,) which denotes the inferior faculties such as are common to brutes ; yea, he extends sanctification even to the body and members of the body.^c For as by sin a spiritual *death* and *irregularity* are bro't upon these faculties, whereby they strive against the spirit :^d Which irregularity is expressly represented as criminal by the Holy Spirit, (1) As it takes place in the *affections* or passions of the soul,^e (2) In the *sensitive* faculties v. g. *seeing*,^f and *bearing*,^g (3) In the bodily *members*,^h &c ; Therefore a spiritual life, by regeneration, must be restored to these faculties, to enable them rightly to discharge their respective services.ⁱ This life in the *inferior* faculties is a *disposition* to *obedience*, whereby they become fitted not to oppose the spirit, or understanding and will, but to be in subjection to, or to be led by the *spirit*.^j As at first, in a state of integrity, by our original righteousness, which consisted in the divine image, those inferior faculties were most beautifully arranged under the government of the mind.

XVII. The spiritual life is bestowed by regeneration, only in the *first act* (or principle) not in the *second acts* (or operation,) understood either as *habits* or *exercises*. For as, by *natural* generation, a man receives neither

^a 1 John 3. 9.
Regeneration
in the inferior
faculties.

^c 1 Thes. 5. 23.

^d Gal. 5. 17.

^e Rom. 5. 7.

Gal. 5. 24.

Col. 3. 5.

1 Thes. 4. 5.

Rom. 1. 26.

^f 2 Pet. 2. 14.

^g Psal. 58. 5.

^h Rom. 6. 19.

and 3. 13, 14,

15, 16.

ⁱ Rom. 6. 10.

^j Gal. 5. 17, 18

Rom. 6. 12, 13

14. 17. Jam.

1. 20.

Regeneration
confers the
spiritual life
in the first act
only.

neither the habits or acts of reasoning, speaking, or writing, but only the *power*, which under proper circumstances, in due time, comes forth into act : So also, in regeneration, there is not bestowed upon the elect, any *faith*, hope, love, repentance, &c. either as to habit or act; but the *power* only of performing these exercises, is bestowed; by which, the regenerate person doth not as yet actually believe, or repent; but only is *capacitated* thereto : Wherefore the unregenerate are emphatically said, to be *unable*, either *to see*, as referring to the understanding, or *to enter*, referring to the will, into the kingdom of God. ^c Which power, in conversion, which succeeds regeneration, proper circumstances being supposed, is, in due time, brought into *actual* exercise. So that one *truly* regenerate may, both as to habit and act, be for a time an unbeliever, destitute of repentance and walking in sin. As appears, more clear than the light of the sun, in the instances of those, who are regenerated in their mothers wombs, or at their baptism, as Jeremiah, ^f John the baptist, ^g and Timothy, ^h who nevertheless did not, till they arrived to the years of discretion, perform the actual exercises of faith or repentance. So that *regeneration*, in which the spiritual life is bestowed in the *first* act or principle only, differs from conversion, by which this principle of life is brought into *actual* exercise, not only in order of *nature*; but sometimes also in order of *time*. However we mean not to deny here, that it may be, and often is the case, that a sanctification of the spirit, in a *general* sense, comprehending vocation, regeneration, conversion & sanctification properly so called, is effected at one and the same time : Which seems to have been the case with the thief on the cross, converted by Christ in his last moments. ⁱ We only mean that they *may* be separated as to time, and that oft times this is *actually* the case.

^a John 3. 3.
and 5.

^f Jer. 1. 5.

^g Luke 1. 15.

^h 2 Tim. 3. 15.

ⁱ Luke 23. 40.

—44—

XVIII. Since therefore regeneration conveys the spiritual life, in the *first* act or principle ; it may be easily determin'd. 1. That in regeneration a man is merely *passive*, as in the first reception of a natural life, the subject of it can be only *merely passive*.^k For if he *did* any thing toward begetting life in himself ; he must be already *alive*, since a dead person cannot act ; and if already *alive*, then surely life is not be- gotten in him.

The affecti-
ons of rege-
neration. 1 A
man is en-
tirely passive
therein.
^k John 1. 43.
with Eph. 2.
5, 6.

XIX. 2. We may determine what ought to be held as to a *preparation* for regeneration : For there may two kinds of preparation come under considera- tion here ; *one*, which is supposed to proceed from the *person* to be regenerated, whereby, he prepares himself to receive regeneration ; or by the power of his own free will he becomes more disposed and prepared for regeneration than others. This, without the plainest contradiction, can by no means be admitted ; since regeneration is an operation upon a man spiritually *dead*, into whom the first act or principle of spiritual life is infused : Now, if he prepared himself thereto, he doubtlessly must do it by a previous principle of *life*, and so must be supposed *alive*, before life is im- planted in him. The *other* kind of preparation is sup- posed to proceed from *God*, the author of regeneration. And again, this preparation, which is the work of God, may respect regeneration, either as taken in a *larger* sense, as denoting conversion also, and the term or immediate end of it, viz. Faith and actual repen- tance, in which conversion terminates : That God useth many preparatory means to regeneration, taken in this sense, by the help of which one may attain to this faith and repentance, we shall endeavour to shew, by divine assistance, in a *future* discourse : Or this preparation may respect regeneration in a more limit- ed sense, as denoting only the introduction of the first act or principle of spiritual life. Nor, in this sense,

2. How far
regeneration
admits of any
preparation.

can

can any preparation, truly and properly so called, be admitted, any more than took place in the resurrection of Lazarus to a natural life.¹ If, however, you chuse to admit here *some kind* of preparation in those, who are to be made the subjects of this spiritual life, such, for instance, as in drying wood, which is to be set on fire, such also as God used in the work of creation, when he created on the first day a shapeless mass, which he formed and modified in the following days, and such as he peculiarly used in the creation of man, forming first the body of clay, or the rib, into which he afterwards breathed *the breath of life*.² I say, if in this sense you chuse, with many orthodox Divines, to admit some *preparation*, which is the work of God, I have no great objection thereto : And then this preparation may consist in the previous external call, so far as God, by the offers of grace, enlightens the mind of the person, who is to be regenerated, concerning the nature of redemption, and the terms of salvation and invites him to embrace the same.

3. In what sense regeneration is irresistible.

* Acts 7. 51.
* Jo. 11. 43. 44.
* Ezek. 36. 25.
26, 27. Jer.
32. 39, 40.
compare Gal.
1. 13. Acts 9
2—6, & 22. 5
with v. 10. &
26. 9, 10. 14,
with ver. 19.

XX. 3. We may hence determine, that regeneration is *irresistible*, and in what sense this is to be understood. For if you consider what the person, who is to be regenerated is, *a child of wrath, dead in sin*; he hath certainly depravity enough to resist : ¹ But if you consider, that it is God, who regenerates and quickens the subject of regeneration can no more *resist* God than Lazarus of old *could* have resisted Christ, who raising him to a natural life.² Nor hath he *a will* to resist, for, by the spiritual life instantaneously produced, all inclination or desire of resisting is suppressed & taken away.³

4. In what sense regeneration is inamissible.

* 1 John 3. 9.
Ezek. 36. 27.
* 11. 19. 20.
Jer. 32. 39. 40

XXI. 4. That the grace of regeneration, can never be *lost*, and the grounds upon which this *Inamissibility* is founded.¹ In this indeed, it differs from the first spiritual life, effected in creation, by the bestowment of original righteousness; through the loss of which

by sin, our first Parents became *spiritually dead*; ^{† Eph. 2. 1. 5.} since the spiritual life bestowed by regeneration is never entirely lost. However, the unfailing permanency of this life is by no means to be ascribed to the *firmness* and constancy of the regenerate, or the *strength and perfection* of the spiritual life; for there is, and always dwells, in the regenerate, so much corruption, that they are as likely, by their own conduct, to destroy this life, as our first parents were; and indeed more so, because they, before the loss of their spiritual life, were *perfectly* righteous and holy.[‡] But the impossibility of losing the grace of regeneration depends, (1) On the grace of election and of the divine purpose, hence the gifts and calling of God are without repentance.[§] And, (2) Upon *preserving* grace.[¶]

XXII. 5. That this spiritual life, as conveyed in regeneration, is but very *imperfect*, it being *only* the first act or principle of spiritual life, and only the *seeds* of spiritual graces, which gradually like the seeds of vegetables, grow up into the stalk, blossoms and fruit. Hence the regenerate, merely as such, are stiled *new born babes*,[‡] *babes in Christ*,[§] who still have need to be nursed, and indeed with food suited to the infantile state: [¶] *That they may grow and wax strong in the spirit*, as is said of John the baptist; [°] that is, in order that the *first* act or principle of life, conveyed in regeneration, might, by conversion, be drawn forth into actual faith and repentance, which are the *second* acts or operations, and, if I may so say, the *branches* of this life: And at length by *sanctification*, produce all these good works, which are the fruits of the spirit.[¶] This spiritual life is indeed so small, that it cannot be well known and distinguished, but by its growth and *exercises*; as *habits* cannot indeed be otherwise known, than by their *Operations*.

THE ARGUMENTATIVE PART.

XXIII. The most of the controversies on this subject may, without much difficulty, be determined from

[‡] Eccl. 7. 29.

[†] Rom. 11. 29.

Math. 24. 22.

[¶] 1 Pet. 1. 5.

John 10. 28,

29.

[§] 5. In what

sense it is im-

perfect.

[¶] 1 Pet. 2. 2.

[°] 1 Cor. 3. 1.

[¶] Heb 5. 12.

13, 14.

[°] Luke 1. 80.

[¶] Gal. 5. 22.

Q. I. Whether
regeneration
consisteth in
reformation
of manners?

our *doctrinal* propositions. The *first* question upon this subject is, Whether regeneration consisteth in a reformation of *manners*? The rank Pelagians, as they deny original sin, the loss of original righteousness, and our being in a state of spiritual death; and hold only to *external* grace, which prescribes to man his duty, and *excites* by arguments to the performance of it: So they allow no regeneration, but what consisteth in a reformation of manners, effected by the *external* grace of God. The Socinians, those rankest Pelagians, tread in their steps, and affirm the same with them. The Reformed consider a reformation of manners, as belonging, not to regeneration, in its strict and proper sense, but to conversion and sanctification; while they place regeneration solely in the reformation of the inner man, the understanding, will, and other faculties, as we have shewn under the *doctrinal* part. Which they support by the following reasons, (1) Man, by breaking the covenant of works, hath lost his *original* righteousness, in which the *spiritual* life of the soul consisteth, (and by the help of which alone our first parents were enabled to perform *spiritual* good, as we have considered in a former discourse,) and so by sin hath contracted *spiritual death*. (2) The scriptures expressly extend regeneration, to the renewing of the inner parts of the soul, to a *new heart*, a new spirit, to the *writing* of the law upon the mind, and upon the heart; as in the *doctrinal* part. (3) A real reformation of *manners*, cannot result from any thing, but a previous *principle of life*, and a renewing of the mind and heart.² Nor have our adversaries any thing to urge in support of the contrary, but their own inconsistent suppositions, such as, (1) That the image of God did not contain *original* righteousness, which we have confuted in a former discourse. (2) That man was not deprived of the image of God, so far as it consisted in *original righteousness*, for transgressing the

law

² 2 Cor. 3. 5. 6.

1 Cor. 2. 14.

Rom. 8. 7.

law of paradise. Which we have already confuted. (3) That man did not by the loss he sustained, contract spiritual death and universal impotence to spiritual and saving good, (which hath been already confuted.) And therefore, (4) That there is nothing needs reformation in man but his *manners* or moral conduct. The falsity of which naturally appears from what hath been already observed.

XXIV. Quest. *Second.* Doth regeneration flow from the free will of man, or from God alone? The rank Pelagians, with whom the Socinians exactly agree, as they suppose that the nature and free will of man were not impaired by the first sin, so they ascribe their regeneration, which they make to consist in a reformation of manners, to free will alone, excepting that they allow grace *externally* directing and influencing in a way of *moral* suasion; yet such grace as may be *rejected* by the free will of man. The Semi-Pelagians, with whom the Jesuits and Arminians agree, admit indeed, that the human nature was impaired by sin; that *blindness* was thereby brought upon the understanding, and a certain *debility* (*tepor*) upon the will: Therefore they hold to some kind of *internal* grace, which may be excited, even as to the will by *external* grace in a way of moral suasion; but such as may nevertheless be *rejected* by the free will of man. The Synergistæ, among the Lutherans, with whom Macrelus, in his ecclesiastical history, reckons Victorinus Strigelius; hold that the *power*, which man *naturally* hath, may contribute *something* towards their regeneration. The Lutherans in general hold, that a man can, by the power of his *free will*, at least refrain from positively *resisting* the Holy Spirit in the work of regeneration, i. e. by the use of external means, he may as it were open the door to the spirit, when he is about to introduce the spiritual life. The Reformed, altho' they allow, that after a spiritual quickening is

Q² Whether regeneration depends upon the free will of man?

Different sentiments.

effected by regeneration, a man may, in conversion, co-operate with God unto the exercising of faith and repentance :^r Yet, in regeneration strictly so called, they deny that a man can do any thing *actively* ; but affirm that he is *merely passive*. Because, (1) *Before* regeneration is effected, man is spiritually *dead* : therefore cannot, either in whole, or in part, contribute any thing towards begetting life in himself : for this contributing of something would suppose *life*. Because, (2) In regeneration there is bestowed a new *heart*, a new *spirit*, on which is written the law of God ; which certainly is to be ascribed to God alone. (3) There is in regeneration a *creation*,^a and a new *creature*,^t which can be attributed only to God.^u (4) *Of ourselves* we are insufficient to think even the least thought, with which *salvation* is connected.^w (5) *God* is said to work in us, *to will* according to his good pleasure.^x (6) The scriptures expressly declare, that it is not of him that *willeth*, or of him that *runneth* ; but of God that sheweth mercy.^z (7) If man were, either in whole, or in part, the author of his own regeneration ; he would make himself to *differ*, contrary to the apostles assertion.^b Nor doth what our adversaries allege, favour their opinion in the least ; as, (1) That we are sometimes commanded to *circumcise the foreskin* of our hearts,^c to *make* to ourselves a new heart, and a new spirit,^d to be *renewed in the spirit* of our minds,^e and to *turn ourselves* to God.^f To this I answer, (1) It is no ways inconsistent, that God should both *command* and *freely bestow* the same thing, according to the well known expression of Austin ; *da, quod jubes* (freely give what thou commandest)—thus God commandeth love ;^g yet it is *he*, that shedeth it abroad in our hearts.^h (2) Those places of scripture, which are alleged, speak not of *regeneration*, strictly so called, by which God *infuseth* the first principle of life ; but of *conversion*, wherein he bringeth forth the life, already bestowed, into actual

^r Cant. 1. 4.
^s Jer. 31. 18.
 Reasons of
 the orthodox
 opinion.

^t Ps. 51. 12.

^u 2 Cor. 5. 17.

^v Isa. 45. 7.

^w 2 Cor. 3. 5.

^x Phil. 2. 13.

^z Rom. 9. 16.

^a 1 Cor. 1. 7.

Heterodox
 objections.

^c Deut. 10. 16.

^d Jer. 4. 4.

^e Ezek. 18. 31.

^f Rom. 12. 2.

^g Joel 2. 13.

^h Mat. 4. 17.

^g Mat. 22. 37.

^h Rom. 5. 5.

tual exercise.¹ They object, (2) That if a man doth nothing towards his own regeneration, but is purely passive, he is regenerated as a *stock*, or *stone*. To which I answer, this by no means follows, since the subject of regeneration hath been previously taught by the *external call* of the gospel, and by *moral* suasion. They object, 3. That to suppose a person doth not exercise a free self-determining power as to his regeneration, would destroy the freedom of the will. To which I answer, (1) A mans free will is no more concerned in his spiritual *regeneration*, than in his natural *generation*. (2) Regeneration is not an *action* of the man, that it should be determined by his free will ; but a mere *passion*, in which he only admits (or is the object of) the action of God, being capable (as a rational creature) of having such an action performed upon him.

XXV. Quest. *Third*. Is the action of God, which regenerateth a man, *moral*, or *physical*? The rank Pelagians with the Socinians, as they place the nature of free will in *indifference*, and suppose also that the free will of man is unimpaired by sin, and therefore that a man, by his own *power*, can do whatsoever God requireth of him ; allow nothing, but a moral *action* or agency of God in regeneration, in which, he *teacheth* what is to be done, and by motives persuadeth to the doing of it. The Semi-Pelagians, together with the Jesuits and Arminians, as they acknowledge some *internal* depravity as the effect of sin ; so they likewise allow some *physical* agency of God in regeneration, which removes that depravity : But, as they restrain the depravity, arising from sin, to the *inferior* faculties of the soul, or at most, to the understanding ; so they allow the physical agency of God, only with respect to these faculties : while, as to the *will* or free will of man, they hold only to a *moral* agency ; yea, they suppose, that this *physical* action of God may be re-
jected

¹ Cant. 1. 4.
Jer. 31. 18.
John 6. 44.
65.

Q 3. whether
the action of
God, which
regenerates,
be moral or
physical.

Different
sentiments.

Arguments
of the ortho-
dox.

ⁱ Eph. 2. 5.
^k Deut. 30 6.
^l Pl. 51. 12.
^m Eph. 2. 10.
ⁿ Ezek. 36.
25, 26, 27.
^o Jer. 31. 33.
^p John 6. 44.
65.

^q Eph. 1. 19,
20.
Heterodox
objections.

^r Deut. 10. 16.
^s Jer. 4. 4.
^t Ezek. 18. 31.
^u Phil. 2. 13.
^v Deut. 10. 15.

^w John 3. 3. 5.

^x Deut. 10. 12.
13.

jected by the power of the will. The Reformed, altho' they acknowledge a moral agency of God in the *external call* of the gospel, which is previous to regeneration ; and tho' they allow both a *physical* and *moral* agency together in *conversion*, which follows regeneration : Yet in regeneration strictly so called, they admit only a mere absolute *physical* agency. Because, (1) Regeneration is the *first* implantation of the spiritual life, before which, the person regenerated was spiritu-ally dead.ⁱ Now moral *suaſion* is no more ſufficient, or even conducive, to the begetting of the *spiritual*, than it is, of the *natural* life. Because, (2) That ſpi-ritual *circumciſion*^k—*new creation*^l—*taking away the heart of ſtone*—*putting within us a heart of fleſh*—*writing the law thereupon*^m—*and drawing*,ⁿ by which terms regeneration is expreſſed, is not a *moral*, but a purely *physical* operation. Because, (3) *That ſuperabundant greatneſs of divine power*, which was exerted in the *raiſing* of Chriſt from the dead, was not *moral*, but *physical* in the higheſt ſenſe : And the apoſtle teſtiſies,^o that the ſame power is exerted in our regeneration. The principal things, which can be urged upon the contrary ſide, are, (1) That we read of God's bringing about regeneration by commanding it, (which, without doubt, beſpeaks a *moral* way of operation) as "*circumciſe the foreſkin of your hearts,*^p *make to yourſelves a new heart,*^q *work out your own ſalvation.*"^r To which I anſwer. In theſe commands God ſpeaks to his *church*, to his people, who had long been his *delight* ;^s therefore they muſt have been already *regenerate* ; ſince, without re-generation, no one can ſee, or *enter into* the kingdom of God.^t Therefore, by theſe *commands*, God doth not mean to bring about *regeneration*, as it denotes the *first* inuſion of the ſpiritual life ; but the drawing forth of that life, which is inuſed by regeneration, into the *ſecond* acts or conſequent exerciſes, (which is expreſſly mentioned in the paſſage,^u from whence the

first of these commands is quoted,) which is done in *conversion*, that follows upon regeneration, in which man *being drawn runs after God*; ^w *being turned, he actively converts and turns himself to God by the power of his grace.*^x It is objected, (2) If regeneration is effected by the *physical* agency of God alone, without any co-operation of the man, then man is regenerated as a *stock* or a *stone*. To which I answer, 1. Regeneration according to the scriptures, respects man as *spiritually dead*,^a as possessed of a *heart of stone*,^b *unfit for any spiritual exercises*:^c But is a man, that is *spiritually dead*, having an heart of stone, and being unqualified for vital operations, in any proper sense, the same as a *stock* or a *stone*? 2. Regeneration is wrought in man, after he hath been externally *called*, to whom grace hath been offered in a way of *moral* suasion, and he invited to the reception of it; thus, so far at least, he is regenerated, not as a *stock* or a *stone*, but as a *man*. It is objected, 3. That, by a *physical* regeneration, the liberty of the will would be impaired and even destroyed. To which I answer: Since by regeneration spiritual life is bestowed upon the will of man, which was before dead, it is so far from being *destroyed*, that it is restored to its proper life and perfection.

^w Cant. 1. 4.^x Jer. 31. 18.^a Eph. 2. 5.^b Ezek. 36.^c 25, 26, 27.^d 2 Cor. 3. 5.

XXVI. Quest. *Fourth*. Doth the physical operation of regeneration affect the *will immediately*? The rank Pelagians, with the Socinians, allow no physical operation of God at all in regeneration; but hold only to a moral and external operation. The Semi Pelagians, with the Jesuits and Arminians, allow *some* physical efficiency in regeneration; but such as affects not the *will*, or free will; but only the *other* faculties of the soul. Some of the Reformed, v. g. John Cameron, and many others allow indeed a physical operation upon the *will*; but that only by the *medium* of the understanding, which God, in regeneration, so *powerfully*

Q. 4. Whether the physical operation of regeneration affects the will immediately.

powerfully enlightens, and convinces, that the will cannot but follow it's last practical dictate. The synod of Dort, with most of the Reformed, extend the physical operation of regeneration to the will, and that *immediately*, as it begets in the will a new *propensity* towards spiritual good, which, in my judgment, is most agreeable to truth. Because, (1) The scriptures do,

Reasons for
the affirma-
tive.

^d Phil. 2. 13.

^e Psal. 51. 12.
Ezek. 36. 25.
26. 27.

^f Gen. 6. 5.
& 8. 21.

^g Rom. 8. 7.

in express terms, ascribe the physical agency of regeneration to the *will*,^d *it is God that worketh in us both to will, &c.* Because, (2) In terms of the same meaning, the scriptures extend it to the *heart*, by which is always meant the will in scripture:^e That God *creates* a new *heart*, and taking away the heart of stone, *puts* this new heart within us, and *writes* his law upon it: most certainly this is done by a *physical* operation. (3) The *will* is itself depraved by sin, as well as the understanding, and inferior faculties;^f hence we frequently read of a *hard heart*, by reason of which, man is not *subject* to the law of God, neither indeed *can be be.*^g

(4) That corruption, which is seated in the *will*, would not be taken away by an illumination of the understanding: nor doth the will follow the last dictate of the practical understanding, unless it dictates agreeably to the *propensity* of the will: v. g. if the will hath a propensity to *carnal* things, and the understanding should judge, in the fullest manner, that spiritual things at this very time, all circumstances considered, were to be proffered; yet the will would not follow: because the will accounts that only *as good*, which is *agreeable* to its propensity. Nor have they, who are of the contrary opinion, any thing to object here, ex-

Objections in
favour of the
negative.

cept, (1) That upon this supposition the *freedom* of the will would be taken away. Which objection we have removed in solving the preceding question. (2) That the will *always* follows the *last* dictate of the practical understanding; therefore, were the understanding but *powerfully enlightened*, so as to judge that spiritual

things

things were better *for them*, than any sensual enjoyments ; the will must necessarily follow : And therefore an immediate operation of God upon the will seems unnecessary, were the understanding but sufficiently enlightened. To which I answer, (1) That last *actual* dictate of the practical *understanding* doth not take away that *habitual* corruption, which is in the will. (2) That, upon the whole, is *good* to the will, which is agreeable to its *inclination* ; wherefore, if the practical judgment determine agreeably to this inclination of the will, the will always follows ; but if contrary thereto, however powerful the dictates of the understanding may be ; yet the will doth not obey : It is therefore necessary, that in regeneration, a new *propensity* be infused into the will towards *spiritual* good, that the practical understanding may dictate agreeably thereto. *

XXVII.

* President Edwards in his enquiry into the freedom of the will, page 12. Boston edition, observes thus, with regard to the will's always following the last dictate of the understanding.

“ It appears from these things, that in some sense, *the will always follows the last dictate of the understanding*. But then the understanding must be taken in a large sense, as including the whole faculty of perception or apprehension, and not merely what is called *reason* or *judgement*. If by the dictate of the understanding is meant what reason declares to be best or most for the person's happiness, taking in the whole of his duration, it is not true that the will always follows the last dictate of the understanding. Such a dictate of reason is quite a different matter from things appearing now most agreeable ; all things being put together, which pertain to the mind's present perceptions, apprehensions or ideas, in any respect. Altho' that dictate of reason, when it takes place, is one thing that is put into the scales, and is to be considered as a thing that has concern in the compound influence which moves and induces the will ; and is one thing that is to be considered in estimating the degree of that appearance of good which the will always follows, either as having its influence added to other things, or subducted from them. When it concurs with other things, then it's weight is added to them, as put into the same scale ; but when it is against them, it is as a weight in the opposite scale, where it resists the influence of other things : yet it's resistance is often overcome by their greater weight, and so the act of the will is determined in opposition to it. ”

Q 5. Whether regeneration be irresistible or not.
Different sentiments.

XXVII. Quest. Fifth. Is regeneration irresistible or not? The rank Pelagians and Socinians, as they allow only a *moral* operation of God in regeneration, and suppose the free will of man to be equally *indifferent*, either to receive, or to reject the divine influence; hold it to be *resistible*: The Semi-Pelagians, with the Jesuits and Arminians, as they hold the regenerating operation to be *physical* in part, as it respects the understanding and inferior faculties; and only *moral* in part, as it respects the will; they maintain that it is in the *power* of the free will, so to resist the divine operation, that regeneration would by no means be effected. Some among the Reformed do not like the term *irresistible*, tho' they admit the term *insuperable*. We have allowed, in the *doctrinal* part, that the *moral* suasion of the *external* call, and also conversion, so far as it is effected by *moral* suasion, is *resistible*: But regeneration we affirm to be absolutely *irresistible*; for the following reasons, (1) Regeneration is effected by the *will* of God,^a which the apostle Paul expressly asserts to be *irresistible*.^b (2) God worketh in us both to *will* and to do,ⁱ and therein taketh away all *inclination to resist*. (3) By regeneration, the Father, who is *greater than all*,^k draweth those who are regenerated.^l And, (4) Draweth them *by the same exceeding greatness of power, by which he raised Jesus from the dead*.^m (5) He so draweth in regeneration, that they, who are drawn, do infallibly *come*.ⁿ (6) By regeneration he taketh away the heart of *stone*, by which we make resistance to the divine call.^o (7) God begeth us by regeneration,^p which act a man can no more resist, than he could his own *natural* generation. (8) By regeneration God *quickeneth*, or maketh alive,^q which the subject of regeneration can no more resist, than a dead man can resist his being raised to a *natural* life, v. g. no more than Lazarus could resist Christ.^r (9) If a man *could* resist, by reason of the *total* corruption of his nature,

Arguments of the orthodox.

^a James 1. 18.

^b Rom. 9. 19.

ⁱ Phil. 2. 13.

^k John 10. 29.

^l John 6. 44.

65.

^m Eph. 1. 19.

20.

ⁿ John 6. 37.

with v. 44.

^o Ezek. 11.

19. & 36. 25,

26, 27.

^p John 1. 13.

^q Eph. 2. 5.

^r John 11. 43.

44.

nature,^s he would continually do it.^t (10) If he could^{s Rom. 7 19.} resist, and yet did not actually resist; he would have^{and 8, 7. Isa.} of himself, the glory of not resisting, and of his own^{1. 5, 6.} regeneration; and so would make *himself* to differ, contrary to the apostle Paul's assertion.^{t Acts 7. 51.} (11) If any one^{1 Cor. 4. 7.} could at his pleasure *resist* the divine agency in regeneration, then *all* could, and so it might be the case, that not one would be regenerated, and thus the whole glorious design of redemption might be *frustrated*, contrary to the apostle Paul's assertion,^{w 2 Tim. 2. 19.} and the golden chain of predestination be broken.^{2 Rom. 8. 30.} What our adversaries object here is of no weight at all, v. g. (1) They allege the words of Stephen, *Ye always resist the Holy Ghost.*² To which I answer: They resisted the Holy Ghost, not when regenerating, but *externally calling*, and that not indeed immediately; but by men, in a *moral* way, as plainly appears from the following *verse*, *Whom of the prophets have not your fathers persecuted?* 2. They allege these words of our Saviour, *How often would I have gathered thy children together, &c. and ye would not?*^b To which I answer: By the expression, *I would have gathered you*, our Saviour doth not mean, by the exertion of a *regenerating* power, but by calling them in a way of *moral* suasion, as the *prophets* did, who were *sent* unto them for *this purpose*, whom they stoned. 3. They object these words from the Psalms, *O that my people had hearkened unto me, and Israel had walked in my ways.*^c To which I answer: ^{c Ps. 81. 14.} The text plainly speaks of resistance made not to regeneration; but to the *external call*: as appears from v. 9. to 12. They object, 4. What is said in Isaiah, *What could I have done more to my vineyard, that I have not done in it?*^d To which I answer: The prophet ^{d Isa. 5. 4.} is speaking, (1) of the benefits purchased by Christ for the *church* in general, not of that special benefit, which is purchased for *each* of the elect in particular. (2) He is speaking of *external* means, not of the grace

of *regeneration* which is *internal*. They object, 5. That, upon this supposition, no one *can* be regenerated, but those who actually are so. To which I answer : With respect to *man*, it is true, no one *can* be regenerated, but he who actually is so ; because all are dead in sin : but, with respect to *God*, all things are possible.* They object, 6. That upon this scheme, they who resist do the *will* of God. To which I answer : They resist the *preceptive* will of God, which only prescribes to rational creatures their duty ; but they do not resist the *decretive* will of God, which governs the event.

* Mat. 19. 26.

Q. 6. Whether there be any preparation to regeneration.

XXVIII. Quest. *Sixth*. Doth regeneration admit of any *preparation* ? The Pelagians and Semi-Pelagians, with all their followers, the Socinians, Jesuits and Arminians, maintain the affirmative ; because they hold that the efficacy of converting grace depends upon the *free will* of man ; and suppose that *one* is by *nature* more prepared for converting grace than *another* ; or that he can thus prepare himself by his own power. The Reformed admit indeed of preparations in regeneration, taken in a large sense, to signify the same as conversion ; thus Perkins in his Cases of Conscience, Sect. I. Ch. v. vi. xi. Dr. Ames in his Cas. Con. Lib. II. Ch. iv. How far preparations may be admitted, and how far not, we have explained in the *doctrinal* part, § XIX. viz. That regeneration, understood to signify only the *first* implantation of the spiritual life, admits of no preparations, excepting what ariseth from the offers and moral invitations of the *external call* of the gospel ; if you chuse to call that a preparation ; because the first implantation of the spiritual life is effected in a moment, just as a resurrection to a natural life is ; nor can there be any middle state between spiritual life and spiritual death.

Q. 7. Whether regeneration can be ever wholly lost.

XXIX. Quest. *Seventh*. Can regeneration once wrought ever be *wholly lost* ? The Pelagians, with all the

the favourers of Pelagianism, maintain the affirmative ; because they strenuously hold to such a *free will* in man, as can either divest itself of grace received, or receive it at pleasure, (with whom, in this point at least, the Lutherans agree ; as they hold that one truly regenerate may totally fall from grace.) The Reformed hold it can never be wholly lost ; but this they suppose to depend, not upon the power of the regenerate, but upon God's immutable decree of *election*, and his almighty upholding power : which is evident from the following reasons, (1) The *seed* of the regenerate is said to abide in them.^f (2) It is said of the regenerate, in consequence of their being endowed with a heart of *flesh*, that they shall walk in God's statutes,^g *shall keep* his judgments and do them. (3) It is evident from the *inseparable* connection there is between predestination and glorification.^h (4) The *foundation of God standeth sure, having this seal, The Lord knoweth them that are his.*ⁱ (5) The *truth* of God stands engaged for the perseverance of the regenerate.^k Nor doth it help our adversaries to object, (1) That a righteous man may *turn* from his righteousness.^l For I answer : The prophet is speaking here, [1] of a *natural power* (*de potentia causæ,*) by which, even the truly righteous considered in themselves, can fall from grace ; but, not of what will actually take place (*de potentia effectûs*) as tho' they, who are upheld by God, could fall away into total apostacy. [2] The prophet speaks *conditionally*, if the righteous man should turn, he would die ; and not *absolutely*, that a truly righteous person can actually fall away. But, [3] The prophet doth not speak of the *truly* righteous, or those who are *internally* so by regeneration, conversion and sanctification, who never can fall away ;^m but of those who were righteous in *appearance* only, or in their *own* estimation.¹ (2) Our adversaries insist upon there being instances of those who have finally fallen away ;

Reasons of the orthodox.

^f 1 John 3.9.^g Ezek. 36.^h 26, 27.^h Rom. 8 30.ⁱ 2 Tim. 2.19.^k 1 Pet. 1.3.4.^j John 10.28, 29.^l Ezek. 3. 20.

and 18. 24.

Objections of the heterodox.

^m Ps. 37. 17

18. 20. 24

¹ 25. 1. 2. 3¹ Math. 9. 3

with Luke

as 18. 9. 10.

¹ John 17. 12. as Judas, ¹ Demas, ^m Hymenæus and Alexander : " To
^m 2 Tim. 4. 10. which I answer, It remains to be proved that they
ⁿ 1 Tim. 1. were ever truly regenerated ; this text is expressly a-
 19. 20. gainst it ; ^o *Whoſoever is born of God doth not commit ſin,*
^a 1 John 3. 9. *for his ſeed remaineth in him, and he cannot ſin ; becauſe he*
is born of God. They object (3) That there are cer-
 tainly inſtances of the truly regenerate, who have fal-
 len from grace, in the drunkenneſs of Noah, the
 adultery and murder of David, Peter's denying his
 Lord, &c. To which I answer, They omitted, or ra-
 ther neglected ſome *ſecond* acts or exerciſes of the ſpi-
 ritual life ; but they never wholly loſt the *firſt* act or
 principle, which was beſtowed in regeneration. ^p They
 object, (4) If the regenerate *cannot* loſe the grace of
 regeneration, they would ceaſe to be *free agents*. To
 which I answer, The conſequence by no means fol-
 lows ; ſince the conſtant preſence of the ſpiritual life
 in the will rather *confirms* the liberty of it.

han deſtroys

Q 8. Whether
 regeneration
 be univerſal.

Different
 ſentiments:

XXX. Queſt. *Eighth.* Whether regeneration be *uni-*
verſal, or whether all men are regenerated ? *All* the
 Papiſts, as well the Dominicans, as the Jeſuits, (as
 they ſuppoſe *ſufficient* grace given to every man, where-
 by he *can* be ſaved) do, in effect, hold regeneration to
 be *univerſal*, (ſince according to the ſcriptures, in re-
 generation properly ſo called, there is conferred *only*
 a *power* to perform ſpiritual good, as we have ſhewn
 under the *doctrinal* part.) However, in the explanati-
 on of this ſufficient grace, they greatly differ. The
 Dominicans indeed ſuppoſe that *ſufficient* grace is gi-
 ven to *all* ; but yet ſuch as cannot put forth itſelf into
actual exerciſe, without *efficacious* grace preceeding :
 But the Jeſuits hold to ſufficient grace, whoſe *efficacy*
 depends upon the free will of every man. The rank
 Pelagians and Socinians, as they make regeneration to
 conſiſt in a *reformation of manners*, ſuppoſe ſinners have
by nature, that power, whereby they *can* regenerate
 themſelves, or reform their moral conduct : But they
 do

do not suppose that an *actual* reformation of manners takes place in every one ; but only in those, who *will* to reform their moral conduct. They expressly exclude regeneration from *infants*, both on account of their having no inherent sin, and also on account of their incapacity, from the want of reason, to reform their moral conduct. Among the Reformed who hold to *universal* grace, there are some who suppose, that by the grace of God power is *restored* to *all*, and every man, whereby they can be saved, if they *will* ; altho' there is given to the *elect* alone that power, by which they are actually made willing. The renowned Cocceius, altho' he doth not deny that regeneration took place under the old testament ; yet in the emphatical sense of it, he confines it to new testament times. The general opinion of the Reformed is, that the grace of regeneration is in the highest sense peculiar to all the *elect* ; and they suppose also that even *infants* are sometimes the subjects of it, which they support by the following reasons, (1) The scriptures, as often as they make mention of regeneration, extend it, not to *all* promiscuously ; but to the *elect* only,^a and that, (2) ' To the exclusion of all others.' (3) The scriptures expressly declare, there are some who have not this *power* which is conferred in regeneration.^b Yea, (4) The scriptures do extend regeneration particularly to *infants*.^c Nor can any place of scripture be produced by our adversaries to the contrary, which testifieth, either that regeneration, the spiritual life, a power of performing spiritual good, or sufficient grace is granted to all and every one.

XXXI. Quest. *Ninth*. Whether regeneration be necessarily connected with baptism ? The Socinians rightly deny it ; but upon a wrong hypothesis, that the baptism of water is but an indifferent rite, introduced by the apostles, without the command of Christ, having no use or efficacy. The Anabaptists likewise deny

The general opinion of the reformed with their reasons.

^a 1 Per. 1. 3.

Eph. 2. 3. 4. 5.

James 1. 18.

John 3. 3—8.

^c John 6. 43,

44. 64. 65.

^b Rom. 8. 7.

Jer. 13. 23.

^c Jer. 1. 5.

Luke 1. 15.

^c 2 Tim. 3. 15.

Q. 9. Whether regeneration be necessarily connected with baptism.

deny it, who allow no use or efficacy of baptism, but that of *signifying* the *church* covenant, and distinguishing those who are in *that* covenant, from those who are without. On the other hand, the Papists, in order to maintain that the sacraments of the new testament beget grace *ex opere operato*, or of their own proper virtue ; hold that the baptism of water effects regeneration, hence they frequently use baptism and regeneration to signify the same thing. The Lutherans do not indeed attribute any regenerating efficacy to the baptismal water ; however they so confine the regenerating influences of the spirit to baptism, that they suppose no one can ordinarily be regenerated without it. The Reformed, tho' they unanimously hold that there is no *physical* regenerating efficacy in baptism ; but only a *moral* efficacy, which consists in its being a *sign and seal* of regeneration ; and also that the grace of regeneration is not confined to any sacrament ; and yet that baptism is not a mere naked, useless *sign*, but a most efficacious *sealing* of the covenant of grace and of *regeneration*, to those who receive it agreeably to it's institution, and also to the *elect infants* of believers : yet as to the manner and time of it's becoming effectual they somewhat differ. Indeed as to the baptism of *adults*, that, if *rightly* administered, doth, by the consent of all the orthodox, certainly presuppose regeneration as already effected ; because it expressly requires faith of the subject of baptism, and such faith indeed as proceeds from the *whole heart* ;* which cannot take place without a previous regeneration : for whatsoever is born of the flesh, is flesh ; and whatsoever is born of the spirit is spirit.^b But as to the baptism of *infants*, here the orthodox are divided ; some deny that regeneration can *precede* baptism, which therefore, as they suppose, only seals regeneration as *future*, when the elect infant shall arrive to years of discretion, so as to be capable of faith and repentance ;

thus

* Acts 8. 36, 37

^b John 3. 6.

thus the celebrated Amyraldus. But he inaccurately confounds *regeneration*, which bestows the spiritual life in the *first* act or principle, (by which the infant is effectually enabled, when he arrives to the exercise of reason, to believe and repent,) with *conversion*; which includes the *actual* exercises of faith and repentance; which cannot take place before the years of discretion. Others, from modesty declining to determine the point, think it depends on the sovereign will of God, whether to bestow regeneration *before* baptism, at the time of its administration, or afterwards; thus Zanchy in his *Commen. upon Eph. v.* in a digression concerning baptism; and Ames in his *Bellarminus enervatus* Tom. III. XIV. Quest. III. Spanheim the father in his *Dub. Evang. Part III. Dub. XXVII.* Others chuse to think that regeneration is effected at the *very time* of baptism, *ordinarily* at least: Thus Lewis Le Blanc, with the Papists and Lutherans, who suppose this always to be the case, thus the celebrated Peter Jurieu, Beza, and others. The common opinion of the Reformed is, that the baptism of infants (at least of the *elect*) presupposes regeneration as already effected; because that which is not, cannot be *sealed* by baptism. And this opinion appears to me most agreeable to truth. Before baptism itself doth not *effect* regeneration, as the Papists suppose; Nor are the regenerating influences of the Holy Spirit *confined* to external baptism, as the Lutherans would have it. Because, (1) The *efficacy* of baptism consists in it's *sealing*, agreeably to the nature of all sacraments so far as they are *seals*; which presupposes regeneration, as the principle of faith. Because, (2) The pollution of the soul is not purged away by the baptism of water, therefore regeneration is not confined thereto. And, (3) If this was the case, all the baptized would be regenerate, and that, at the very time of their baptism: Against which the scriptures speak,* and also experience shews,

The general opinion of the reformed, with their reasons,

* Rom. 4. 11.

* 1 Pet. 3. 21.

* Acts 8. 13.

that 20. 21. 23.

- that many baptized persons live most abandoned lives, and are not finally saved. We read also of persons regenerated *before* their baptism, as the Eunuch,^f the Centurion and his family ;^g yea, of those who were never baptized at all, as the thief upon the cross ;^h according to the common observation, *that it is not the want of baptism, but the contempt of it that is damning.*
- (4) Regeneration is limited to no sacrament, not to *circumcision*,ⁱ not to the *passover*,^a not to the *Lord's supper*,^k nor to any legal washings,^l therefore not to baptism, since 'tis expressly said, that even a baptized person, if he believes not, shall be damned.^m I will only add, (5) That the Holy Ghost is said to regenerate according to his sovereign pleasure ; *as the wind bloweth where it listeth, so is every one born of the Spirit.*ⁿ 'Tis however alleged in favour of the contrary side, (1) That Christ hath inseparably connected regeneration with *water and the spirit.*^o To which I answer : He doth not mean the external water of baptism, which at that time was not instituted as an ordinary and universal sacrament of the new-testament ; but by *Hendiadis*, he means the water of the Spirit, or the Spirit cleansing, like water, in the work of regeneration. In like manner it is said, *he will baptize you with the Holy Ghost and with fire,*^p i. e. with the Spirit, having the purifying quality of fire ; which our Saviour sufficiently shews to be his meaning, when he ascribes regeneration to the Spirit alone :^b Compare herewith what hath been said upon this point in the *explanatory* part. 'Tis alleged, (2) That the washing away of sin,^q regeneration,^r and salvation^s are ascribed to baptism ; therefore baptism either works regeneration by it's own virtue, or at least the Holy Spirit hath inseparably connected his regenerating influences therewith. To which I answer : Neither of these is the case ; but only that the Holy Spirit, by baptism, sealeth regeneration to the elect ; as we have already observed.

observed. (3) They argue on the other side from this text, *Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ, were baptized into his death?* To which Rom. 6. 3. I answer: This text means only that all the elect, being true believers, baptized according to institution, have communion and participation in the death of Christ, which is sealed to them by baptism: But it is not said that this communion is effected particularly by baptism, much less, that this communion is absolutely connected with baptism. 'Tis argued, (4) As many as are baptized into Christ, *put on Christ*, consequently are regenerated." To which I answer: The Gal. 3. 27. text doth not say that they *put on* Christ by baptism; but that they, who are baptized, had *before* put on Christ. Since therefore communion with Christ, which is signified by the term of putting on Christ, hath been already effected in baptized persons, 'tis not effected by baptism; but being already effected, is sealed by this sacrament. (5) 'Tis argued by those of the contrary opinion, that theirs is the received opinion of the fathers, and also of eminent men among the Reformed themselves, v. g. of Austin and Prosper among the Fathers, of Pareus, Davenant, Ward and Forbes among the Reformed. To which I answer: The Fathers, whenever they speak of baptism, are wont to use very strong expressions; nevertheless, they very often suppose regeneration and faith as previous to baptism: Thus Justin Martyr, representing the practice of the primitive church, saith, "*Whoever have been persuaded and have believed—and have received power so to live—are then brought by us to the water and are* REGENERATED, *after the same mode of regeneration, in which we ourselves have been regenerated.*" The Fathers therefore can by no means be reconciled with each other, without a distinction of regeneration into *real*, which *precedes* baptism, and *sacramental* which consists in a solemn profession, declaration and sealing of that,

which is *real*. In which sense the Reformed divines also hold that regeneration is effected by baptism.

THE PRACTICAL PART.

Practical instruction.]

XXXII. You will now perhaps, reader, promise yourself a very large application of this important subject, since practical writers have so much exerted themselves upon it. But, if I shall not fully answer your expectations, you will consider these two things.

(1) Those practical writers treat the subject of regeneration in a *larger* sense, as comprehending the *whole* internal operation of the Holy Spirit upon the re- deemed, in which are contained vocation, spiritual quickening, conversion and sanctification; whilst we have taken it in a *stricter* sense, as denoting only the bestowment of the *first act* or principle of spiritual life: Hence they bring under regeneration those things which properly belong to conversion and sanctification.

If the reader is pleased to consider this subject in the same latitude with them; he may, without much difficulty, apply here, what is said, by way of improvement, under the heads of conversion and sanctification.

(2) It is to be considered here, that the *first act* of life is conferred, only in order to the *second acts*, as habits are only in order to their second acts or exercises; nor can it be known or discerned, but by the exercises of it: and also that an unregenerate person cannot strive to beget life in himself, or cannot dispose himself thereto, since he is merely *passive* in the reception of the spiritual life: Wherefore you will not wonder, if we do not labour so much upon the practical part of this subject. However the subject of regeneration teacheth us,

7. This subject teaches how great a work it is to recover the sinner to life.

XXXIII. *First*. How great a work it is to recover the sinner to life; so that reason, not without cause, enquires with Nicodemus, *How can a man be born again when he is old?* And justly were the apostles astonished, upon a similar topic, when they cried out, *Who*

John 3. 4.

then

then can be saved?^{*} For if you consider the subject, who is to be made alive; he is spiritually dead, dead in sin;^a *who seeing doth not see, and hearing doth not hear, or understand.*^b If you consider the work itself, this is effected only by a second generation,^c a creation,^d quickening,^e taking away the heart of stone, putting within us a heart of flesh, writing the law of God upon the heart,^f or by a renovation of the whole man.^g If you consider the manner of operation, this requireth in the author of it, (1) Infinite power, & superabundant greatness of power, as great, and, if possible, even greater, than was exercised in creation: Because there was not only no necessity, in order to creation, of the death of the Son of God, as there is in the restoring of a sinner to life: But there was no contrary disposition of the object, such as an heart of stone, which knows not how to believe, superable by nothing short of infinite strength: As great a power also is necessary, as was required to raise the dead.ⁱ (2) It requires in the author of regeneration, infinite or exhaustless goodness and mercy,^k by which, that we may not all perish eternally by the first generation, he is pleased to add a second: And lest, by the first life, we contract eternal death, he is pleased to add the second: And that our souls may not be dead in living bodies, he is pleased to restore to them the spiritual life lost by sin. It requires, (3) Infinite, or the most absolute sovereignty;^l hereby, passing by whom he will, he bestows the spiritual life on whom he pleases: passing by for the most part, the more noble, and as it were the more worthy, he bestows it on the more mean and contemptible,^m and of materials in themselves so unsuitable, he is pleased to rear an edifice so magnificent. As appears in the case of Zacheus,ⁿ — f Paul^o — of the harlots in preference to the reputable Pharisees.^p Regeneration inculcates the greatness of the work of restoring a sinner to life, for these ends, (1) That we might more particularly acknowledge,

^{*} Mat. 19. 25.^a Eph. 2. 1. 5.^b Mat. 13. 13.^c 14. 15.^d John 3. 3. 5.^e Psalm 51. 12.^f Eph. 2. 10.^g Eph. 2. 5. 6.^h Ezek. 36.ⁱ 25. 26.^j 2 Cor. 5. 17.^k Eph. 1. 19. 20.^l Eph. 1. 20.^m Eph. 2. 4. 5.ⁿ and ch. 3. 8. 9.^o Rom. 9. 15.^p 16. 18.^q 1 Cor. 1. 25.^r — 29.^s Luke 19. 7.^t 5. 8.^u 1 Tim. 1.^v 13. 14.^w Mat. 21. 31.

ledge, what great *obligations* we are under to God, that he hath regenerated and brought us into a state of life, while so many thousands are passed by, and that we might shew ourselves more ready to make *grateful returns*.^a (2) That, on account of the infinite power, goodness and benevolence, which God hath exhibited in our regeneration, we might be the more careful to live to his glory.^c (3) That with regard to our future happiness, we might more humbly depend upon his *grace*, and work out our salvation with *fear and trembling*; because it is *God* alone, who worketh in us both *to will and to do*.^e (4) That we might not, from our state's being better than that of others, *exalt* ourselves above them;^f that we might not *boast*,^g since it is *God alone*, who, by regeneration, makes us to differ from the worst of mankind; and whatever good we have above them, we derive it wholly from him.^h (5) That we might not wonder if the most powerful arguments to conversion, used by men, have not always answerable success; since it is not *of Paul*, that planteth, nor *Apollos*, that watereth, but *of God*, that giveth the increase;ⁱ for the Spirit, in his regenerating influences, *bloweth where he listeth*;^j and the *natural* man is naturally *dead in sin*;^k and the Father *draweth* not all promiscuously.^l (6) That we might not readily despair of the conversion of *any one*, however great his opposition thereto may be;^m for the Spirit is *able* to regenerate and quicken him, when it seemeth good in his sight.

2. It recommends to us the blessedness of the regenerate.

XXXIV. *Secondly*. This subject recommends to us the *happy* condition of those, who, with so much difficulty, have been brought, by regeneration, to a spiritual life: *Blessed be God—who hath begotten us to a lively hope*—For, (1) *they are born not of flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God*.ⁿ (2) They are made *alive* from the *dead*.^o (3) They are by way of eminence the *workmanship* of God;^p in a peculiar manner produced by him.

^a 1 Pet. 1. 3.
^c John 1. 13.
^e Luke 15. 22.
^f Ep. 2. 10. Pf.
^g 100. 3. compared with
Deut. 32. 6.

him.¹ (4) They are *new creatures*,^k in many respects more excellent than any other creature. For whilst every other creature flows from the *common* goodness of the Creator ;¹ this *new* creature flows from his *singular grace* and promise.^m Whilst every other creature performs the work of *common* providence ;ⁿ this *new* creature performs the work of gracious predestination.^o Whilst every other rejoices, only in the *natural* benefits of God ; this new creature is loaded with *spiritual* blessings.^p (5) Instead of an insensible, *stoney* heart, they have a heart of *flesh*, easily affected, which carries the law of God written upon it.^q (6) From persons dead, they are become *spiritually alive*.^r (7) They carry about them the Divine Image, which is restored to them, which is their peculiar prerogative, *h. e. original righteousness*.^s And what is more, (8) They are made partakers of a *divine nature*.^t Yea, by regeneration, since they are *born of God*,^u they become the children of God ; not only by adoption, or *declaration*, as Jacob the patriarch adopted Ephraim and Manasseh ;^w but also by a *spiritual generation*. How are the regenerate *enabled* hereby !^x How glorious is their inheritance !^y How great is the *liberty* of the sons of God !^z How free their *access* to God in every difficulty !^a How great their *security* under the paternal and domestic care of their heavenly Father !^b (9) They are by this *spiritual generation* endowed with *eyes*, by which they *can see* the kingdom of God,^c and *spiritually* discern the spiritual objects of it ;^d and moreover with a *heart*, by which they are both able and willing to enter into the kingdom of God.^e If now you cast up the sum of all these blessings, good God ! how great doth the *blessedness* of the truly regenerate appear to be ? How careful then should we be to represent it aright ? That such may *congratulate* themselves upon this unspeakable gift of God :^f That they may be filled with *gratitude* to God :^g That they may *show* to others the greatness

¹ Tit. 2. 14.^k 2 Cor. 5. 17.¹ Psa 104. 31.

and 145. 9.

^m Eph. 2. 4 5.ⁿ Acts 17. 25.^o 28.^p Rom. 8. 29.^q 30. Jam. 1. 18.^r Pl. 4 7. 8. &

17. 14. 15.

^s Eph. 2. 4 5. 6.^t ch. 1. 3.^u Ezek. 36.^v 25. 26.^w Eph. 2. 45. 6.^x Eph. 4. 23.^y 24. Col. 3. 10.^z 2 Pet. 1. 4.^a John 1. 13.^b & 1 Joh. 5. 14.^c Gen. 48. 5.^d 1 John 3. 1.^e Rom. 8. 15.^f Rom. 8. 21.^g Rom. 8. 15.^h Gal. 4. 6.ⁱ Eph. 2. 18. 19.^j John 3. 3.^k 1 Cor. 2. 14.^l 15.^m John 3. 5.ⁿ Ps. 116. 16.^o 1 Pet. 1. 3.

^k Luke 8. 39. greatness of this blessing, to excite their eager desires
 Mat. 5. 16. and longings after it.^k

1 Pet. 1. 2.

3. It represents the misery of the unregenerate in six particulars.

^l John 3. 3. 5.

^m John 1. 13.

ⁿ Joh. 8. 42. 44.

^o 2 Tim. 2. 26.

^p Eph. 2. 1. 5.

Ezek 37. 1. 2.

^q 1 Cor. 2. 14.

^r Acts 7. 51.

^s Ezek. 36. 25.

^t Eph. 4. 18. 19.

^u Jer. 6. 10.

^x Acts 7. 51.

^y Rom. 8. 7.

compared with 2 Cor.

3. 3.

^a Ps. 132. 9.

^b Rom. 1. 31.

^c Mat. 22. 32.

^d Mark 14. 21.

compared with Job 3. 3

—9. Jer. 20.

14. 15.

^e Eph. 2. 10.

^f Mat. 25. 41.

Isa. 66. 24.

XXXV. *Thirdly.* This subject represents, upon the other hand, the unspeakable *misery* of those, who are destitute of the grace of regeneration. Because, (1) They cannot even see the kingdom of God, much less enter therein; hence they are utterly excluded from the very threshold of eternal salvation.^l (2) So long as they are not born of God,^m they are born of their father the devil, and so are the children of the devil.ⁿ (3) They are spiritually dead,^o entangled in his snares.^o (3) They are spiritually dead in sins,^p they see not the things of the spirit^q—have hearts of stone—are obstinate in wickedness,^r and are immoveable to that which is good.^s They are also stupid, insensible,^t impenetrable by any moral operations of the Holy Spirit.^u Yea, they are striving against the spirit:^x They are not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can they be.^y So that you might sooner squeeze water from a stone, than excite repentance in them. They are like stones, cold, destitute of all warmth, of all spiritual love towards God, his grace, or the salvation of their own souls:^a They are without natural affection (*astorgoi*;) ^b and from all these things, surely without the covenant of grace; for God is not a God of the dead.^c (4) So long as they remain unregenerate, it were better for them not to have been born, which our Saviour expressly declares concerning Judas;^d and the unregenerate, in hell hereafter, will curse the day of their birth. (5) So long as they are not the workmanship of God by the grace of regeneration,^e it were better for them never to have been created by God, before not to have been made men; but rather the lowest and most despicable reptiles: because from the immortality of their souls, immortal, yea, eternal misery awaits them;^f whilst these reptiles will be forever insensible. (6) So long as they are not, by regeneration, brought back to God, they are alienated from

from the life of God,^a are *afar* off from God,^b with an immense gulph, as it were, fixed between them.ⁱ They are cast out with Cain from the presence of God;^k are without God in the world;^l are *afar* off from the knowledge of God, and of divine things;^m seeking after God, as it were by *feeling* after him in the dark;ⁿ *afar* off also from the love and saving grace of God;^o and also from Christ, from the commonwealth of Israel, from the covenants of promise and from all hope of salvation.^p

To paint in the most lively manner this great misery of the unregenerate is of great service, (1) To ourselves, that we may hence conceive a greater horror of that state, and groan out with David, *Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me, that we might work out our own salvation with fear and trembling: for it is God which worketh in us, both to will and to do.*^q And that we might rejoice with trembling, in that we have received the grace of regeneration. (2) It may be of service to others, who are yet in an unregenerate state, that, by divine assistance, they might awake (or recover themselves) from the snares of the devil, by which they are led captive at his will.^r

XXXVI. Fourthly. This subject admonishes us that we should avoid more than we would the most venomous animal, the resting, in the business of our souls salvation, in any thing, however specious, short of regeneration. And that for the following reasons. (1) It appears from the most solemn repeated assertions of our Saviour, that it is impossible, without regeneration, either to see or enter into, the kingdom of God.^s (2) Whatever is born of the flesh, h. e. proceeds from a carnal unregenerate man, is only carnal.^t (3) Thousands, by taking things natural for things spiritual, nature for grace, a good natural disposition for regeneration, have miserably deceived themselves, and under this deception have perished eternally;^x and

our 12.

* In our translation "who are taken captive by him at his will."

^aEph. 4. 17. 18
^bEph. 2. 13. 17
ⁱLuke 16. 26.
^kGen. 4. 14.
^lEph. 2. 12.
^mEph. 4. 18.
ⁿ1 Cor. 2. 14.
^oActs 17. 27.
^pIsa. 59. 2.

^qEph. 2. 12.
For what end this representation is to be made.
^rPf. 51. 12.
^sPhil. 2. 13.
^tPf. 2. 11.

^u2 Tim. 2. 26.
^v4. That we should not rest in any thing which is not absolutely connected with regeneration.

^wJohn 3. 3. 5.
^xJohn 3. 6.

^yLuk. 18. 11.

our Saviour declares that Publicans and Harlots should enter into the kingdom of God *before* the Pharisees.^a Particularly we should avoid, in the business of our salvation, resting, (1) In a more *virtuous, natural* disposition: By which thro' a certain native *goodness of temper*, as tho' they were formed of pure² clay, some among the Heathen have been more inclined than others, to mildness, humanity, civility, clemency, equity, and the like; upon which account the more moral *Pharisee* gives thanks to God, that he was not like other men, particularly the Publican, who was standing near him.^b Nor, (2) should we rest in any natural *gifts* which may be acquired; wherein one excelleth another among the Gentiles, and likewise among pretended Christians. v. g. In learning, wisdom, prudence, skill in mechanicks or philosophy, v. g. such as Ahithophel,^c Bezaleel and Aholiab^d were possessed of. Nor, (3) in *moral virtues*, from which the Gentiles are said to have the *law of God written upon their hearts*,^e yea they are said to do, *by nature, the things contained in the law*; ² in which virtues, (v. g.) Plato, Cato, Scipio, Cicero, Aristides, Seneca, and the Antonini, a thousand degrees exceeded Cataline, Caligula, Nero, Heliogabulus, and others. Yea the Gentiles have herein some times out-done God's *professing* people. v. g. Tyre and Sidon excelled the inhabitants of Bethsaida and Chorazin: ² The Sodomites, the inhabitants of Capernaum; ^b and the queen of the South, the Jews.¹ Nor, (4) may we rest in any *ecclesiastical* or external duties of religion; such as the *acknowledgement* of the truth,^k the *profession* of it,¹ *disputing* for it,^m a frequent *attendance* upon holy exercises,ⁿ the use of the sacraments,^o bestowing of alms,^p fasting,^q suffering martyrdom for the truth,^r *preaching* the word,^s or in a *zealous* profession.^x Nor, (5) may we rest in any kind of external *righteousness*,² a conversation that is morally honest,^b or a blamelessness as to the *righteousness of the law*.

the law.^c Nor, (6) may we rest in the gifts of *common*^e grace ;^d such as, (1) the common *illumination* of the Holy Spirit ;^e in consequence of which, we may acknowledge the saving truth, receive it with joy, profess it courageously, and preach it with zeal : (2) The powerful *restraining* influences of the spirit.^f (3) Some kind of *detestation* and avoidance of enormous crimes.^g (4) A kind of *repentance* for gross sins, wherein we acknowledge them, are sorry for them, confess them, and in a degree reform our lives, as Judas did :^h (5) *Math.* 27. 3. An *external* observance of the law and precepts of God.ⁱ In all these things therefore, and many others,^j a man must never *rest*, in the great business of his salvation, if he means not to be deceived ; for all these things may be found in persons destitute of the spirit, or his *regenerating* influences, arising merely from *fleshly* principles, therefore they may be only of a *carnal* nature :^k Altho' in the truly regenerate these things may take their origin from the spirit or the spiritual life infused. Wherefore it is absolutely necessary, that in all these things, we accurately distinguish the *nature* of them from the grace of regeneration, and mark their defects, from which we may clearly know, that they flow not from the *spirit*, or the spiritual life of regeneration ; but from the *flesh*, that is from unregenerate nature. Those *moral* duties therefore differ from spiritual ones. 1. As to their *origin* ; for whilst spiritual things originate from the *spirit*,¹ and are the fruit of the spirit,² and proceed from the law of God,³ written by the spirit upon the heart ;⁴ those moral duties are effected *merely* by industry, study and practice, and are excited by the powers of free will, and are therefore only the works of *nature*, not of the *spirit*. 2. They differ as to the *rule* : whilst *spiritual* duties conform themselves to the rule of the *new* creature,⁵ and they, that are spiritual walk after the *spirit*,⁶ and according to the will of God ;⁷ the *morality* of the

Phil. 3. 6.
^d Heb. 6. 4.
^e Num. 24. 3. 4.
^f Gen. 20. 6.
^g 1 Cor. 5. 11.
^h Math. 27. 3.
ⁱ 4. 5.
^j 1 Kings 21. 27.
^k Mat. 19. 18.
 19. 20.
^k John 3. 6.
 How moral duties differ from spiritual.
¹ John 3. 5.
² Gal. 5. 22.
³ Jer. 31. 33.
⁴ Ezek. 36. 26.
 27.
⁵ Gal. 6. 16.
⁶ Rom. 8. 1.
⁷ Mat. 6. 10.

H
unregenerate

unregenerate is regulated by a kind of *mediocrity*, which reason and the sentiments of wise men have fixed. Therefore this morality is not obedience performed unto God, but to *reason* and wise men. 3. They differ as to the *end*: whilst the *regenerate*, in the performance of *spiritual* duties, aim at the *glory* of God,^r and after union and communion with him, in which their greatest happiness consisteth:^s The *unregenerate* in their *moral* duties seek chiefly their *own* glory and interest, as was evidently the case with the Pharisees:^o or if something higher excites them to the pursuit of *virtue*, at most 'tis only the *beauty* of virtue, as being agreeable to reason. 4. They differ as to the immediate *cause*: whilst spiritual duties flow from faith,^t which accounts as sin whatsoever is not of *itself*, however specious it may appear:^u These *moral* duties know nothing of *faith*, they grow from the seeds of *nature*, and are watered by exercise, without any earnest seeking of divine assistance. 5. They differ as to the *foundation*: whilst all *spiritual* duties have their existence, and are performed in *Christ*, without whom we *can do nothing*,^v and by whom we *can do all things*;^x nor are they acceptable to God, except in Christ the beloved;^z as, by his righteousness he covers, and makes amends for, all the defects of these duties, and so presents them to his father: The *morality* of the unregenerate hath *nothing* of Christ in it, and is therefore but the *tares* of nature, their own righteousness, and like a *menstruous* garment, abominable in the sight of God.^a 6. They differ as to the *affection* of humility: whilst *spiritual* exercises are joined with a constant sense and acknowledgement of their native unfitness and corruption, and consequently with profound humility:^b This *morality* puffeth up and savours rankly of pride and arrogance.^c

^r 1 Cor. 10. 31.^s Phil. 1. 20.^t Pl. 16. 5. &^u 73. 25.^o Mat. 6. 2. 5.^v John 15. 3.^x Phil. 4. 13.^z Eph. 1. 6^a If 64. 6.^b Luke 17. 10.

and 18. 13

^c 2 Cor. 3. 5.^d Mat. 6. 2. 5. 8.

Luke 18. 11.

^e 2 If. 58. 2. 3.

Mat. 7. 26.

XXXVII. *Fifthly.* This subject recommends to us, an impartial *examination* of ourselves, that we may know, whether we are truly regenerate or not. Altho' the *first* act or principle of spiritual life, which is conferred in regeneration, be not evident *of itself*, any more than the *first* act or principle of natural life, or any habit or virtue : It is however very conspicuous in its *operations*, which it puts forth in conversion : and altho' a person, before one of good *moral conversation*, cannot easily be certain that he is *not* regenerate, because the life of regeneration may sometimes, like seed in the earth, lie hid for a time : however he that is truly regenerated and converted can, from the *fruits* of the spirit, ^a be absolutely certain of his regeneration and conversion : ^c Before he, that brings *not* forth fruits, meet for repentance, may justly *doubt* of his regeneration, so as to be sensible that he stands in need of it. By what evidences then shall I certainly know that I am regenerated ? I answer by these which follow, 1. Whoever experiences within himself a general *renovation*, by which, from a *carnal*, worldly man, he becomes *spiritual* and heavenly, he without doubt is regenerate : for regeneration is the *renovation* of the Holy Spirit, ^f and a regenerate person is a *new creature*, ^g who hath received a *new* heart, a *new* spirit, ^h and is transformed into the *image of God*, ⁱ so that it is no longer *he that liveth*, but *Christ in him*. ^k 2. Whoever, instead of his former *blindness*, experiences new *light*, by which he can know and discover spiritual objects in a *spiritual* manner, he is most certainly regenerate. ^l 3. Whoever, in his heart and will, experiences a new *propensity* towards spiritual objects, he without doubt is a regenerate person. ^m 4. Whoever in the *affections* or passions of his soul, in love and hatred, desire and aversion, joy and sorrow ; likewise anger, fear and courage, experiences a more *spiritual* constitution than before ; he is most certainly regenerate. ⁿ 5. Whoever seriously strive after *growth* in spiritual things, that they may

5. This subject recommends examination of ourselves, whether we are truly regenerate or not.

^a Gal. 5. 22. Mat. 7 16.—21.

^c 1 John 3 14. and 5. 1.

By what evidences a may be certain that he is regenerate.

^f Tit. 3. 5.

^g 2 Cor. 5. 18.

^h Ezek 36. 26.

ⁱ 2 Cor. 3. 18.

^k Gal. 2. 20.

^l Eph. 1. 13.

& 5. 8. 1 Cor.

2. 14. 15.

^m 2 Cor. 4. 3. 6.

Abs 26. 18.

ⁿ Phil. 3. 7. 8.

Psal. 4 7. 8.

and 16 5. and

73. 25. Phil.

1. 20.

^a Gal. 5. 16.

17. 24 Rom.

8 1 2 and 7

20. 21.

increase

1 Pet. 2. 2. *increase* more and more in the things which pertain to
 Math. 18. 3. the kingdom of God, and be changed for the better ;
 Eph. 2. 10. they without doubt are regenerate.^o 6. Whoever are
 Col. 1. 10. Acts 9. 6. Rom. 1. *inclined* to every good work, are most certainly regene-
 9. 6. rated ; for we are in Christ Jesus, by regeneration,
 & 7. 22. *created unto good works.*^p On the other hand, the fol-
 2 Pet. 1. 4. 5. 6. lowing characters have just reason to doubt of their
 7. 8. reasons for regeneration, (1) As many as *live* not after the *spirit*,
 reasons for doubting of but after the *flesh* ; for whatsoever *is born of the flesh, is*
 one's regener- *flesh* ; ^q who are under the *dominion* of sin, led captive
 ration. by the snares of satan.^r (2) All they, who *despise* and
 9 Joh. 3. 6. account as of no value the *means* of grace and salvati-
 12 Tim. 2. 25. 26 on.^s (3) Whoever *rest* in a civilly *honest* and pharisaical
 Eph. 2. 1. 2. 3. life.^t (4) Whoever stop in the external *professions* of
 4 5. Rom. 8. piety, and labour not for the *internal* exercises of it.^u
 13. & 6. 12. & 7 4. 5. 6. ^s Joh. 8. (5) As many, as were never *deeply* concerned about
 45. 2 Tim. 2. 25. 26. ^t Mat 5 their salvation, or the spiritual state of their souls.^w
 20 Lu. 18 11. XXXVIII. *Sixthly.* This subject inculcates upon
 12 Ph. 3. 4. 5. 6 us, to strive earnestly for the regeneration of others :
 Rom. 2. 17 which is especially incumbent on the *ministers* of God's
 6. This sub- word. For since the unregenerate can do nothing
 ject inculcates upon us to towards regenerating *themselves*, 'tis necessary, every
 strive earnest- ly for the re- one should strive therefor ; they especially whose bu-
 generation of siness God hath made it *ex officio* (from their office.)
 others. And for their encouragement herein, it may be well
 Motives thereto seriously to consider, (1) That they are *called* hereto
 12 Tim. 3. 5. by God.^x (2) That, herein they act as *fellow labourers*,
 Mat. 7. 21. 22. with God.^a (3) That, on this-account, they are called
 23. Mt. 58. 2. *fathers*, because they beget spiritual children.^b (4)
 Ezek. 33. 51. How important a thing the human *soul* is.^c (5) How
 32. 1 Cor. 13. 3. glorious it is to *win* souls to Christ.^d So that Austin
 Jer. 31. 19. not improperly declared, that the conversion of a soul
 Acts 2. 37. exceeded any *miracle*. (6) How *glorious* it will be for
 2 Acts 26. 17 them hereafter, in the last day, to have begotten many
 18. 2 Cor. 5. 18 to a spiritual life.^e (7) On the other hand, how *dis-*
 19. 2 Tim. 2. 25. 26. *graceful*, how horrible it will be, to be found guilty of
 21 Cor. 3. 9. the neglect of *souls*.^y But in what manner shall they
 2 Cor. 6. 1. labour
 1 Cor. 4. 15. labour
 4 Mat. 16. 26. labour
 Luke 9 25. ^d Prov. 11. 20. Mat. 4 19. ^e Heb. 2. 10. 13. 1 Thes. 2. 19. 2 Cor.
 1. 14. Dan. 12. 3. ^y Ezek. 3. 18. 20. Jer. 48. 10. 1 Cor. 9. 16. 17.

labour for the regeneration of others? *Ans.* 1. By teaching and instructing them concerning the nature of regeneration as Christ did Nicodemus.^f 2. By inculcating the absolute necessity of regeneration, without which they can neither see, nor enter into the kingdom of God.^g 3. By laying open the unspeakable misery of those who die without regeneration,^h as in § xxxv. 4. By powerfully representing the happy condition of those who are truly regenerate, as in § xxxiv. 5. By pointing out the means, (*adminicula*) whereby we may become partakers of regenerating grace; such as, v. g. (1) To avoid with Nicodemusⁱ intimacy with the unregenerate,^k and seek, as he did, the company and instruction of those, who can point out to us the life of regeneration.^l (2) To conceive the seed of regeneration^m the word of God. (3) To urge the promise of the covenant of grace.ⁿ (4) To groan out with David, *Create within me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me, &c.*^o 6. By removing prejudices, pretences and impediments, by which the unregenerate are wont to block up their way to regeneration; such as v. g. (1) That they shall thereby be obliged to condemn themselves, and openly expose all their past life with the greatest disgrace to themselves. To which this answer may be given, [1] Whatever small disgrace it may be, we must cheerfully submit to it, if we would avoid eternal disgrace.^p [2] The very best of men never were ashamed to confess their sins and condemn their wicked lives:^q and by the consent of all christians, this is absolutely necessary to salvation.^r [3] 'Tis even an honor to a man, ingenuously to retract whatever he hath done amiss,^s and recount his past crimes to the glory of divine grace.^t Obj. 2. That in this way, they must begin every thing anew, and pull down all that they have been building up before: *Ans.* What hath been badly built, should be pulled down, lest it fall of itself; as is plainly the case with

The way in which we should strive for the regeneration of others.

^f John 3. 4 5.
^g John 3. 3-5.
^h Rom 7. 24.
ⁱ Tim. 2. 26.
^j Luke 13. 3.

^k John 3. 2.
^l Acts 2. 38. 40

^m 1 Cor. 4. 15.
ⁿ Prov. 13. 20.
^o Eph. 4. 29.
^p 1 Pet. 1. 23.
^q 1 Cor. 4. 15.
^r Ezek. 36. 25.
^s 26. 27. and
11. 19. Jer.
32. 39.
^t Ps. 51. 12.

^u Dan. 12. 2.

^v Ps. 51.—
^w 1 Cor. 11. 33.
^x Prov. 28. 13.
^y 2 Cor. 3. 2.
^z 1 Tim. 1. 13.
^{aa} Tit. 3. 3. 4.
^{ab} 1 Cor. 6. 10. 13.

with buildings, whose foundations are rotten and poor.^e Obj. 3. That by bringing into doubt all their former conduct, they shall be brought into a state of despair. Anf. (1) It is better to despair here, where there is *hope*, than hereafter to be in *hopeless* despair forever. (2) This salutary despair of their past wrong ways, is really a substantial *hope*, yea, an undoubted means of bringing them back into the way of eternal salvation. Obj. 4. That they can't come up to that *strictness of life*, which belongs to regeneration and the new creature. Anf. (1) 'Tis thro' *straits* and difficulties that we arrive to any thing glorious.^a (2) The way is not difficult, but pleasant, to the truly regenerate.^w Obj. 5. That hereby they shall become exposed, to the censures, reproach and persecutions of the world. Anf. [1] This is the common lot of Christians; and happy is he, in the opinion of Christ, who is *not offended* hereby.^a [2] In these very *afflictions* consisteth one of the christian *beatitudes*.^a 7. We should seek the regeneration of sinners, by praying for them, that God would give *success* to his own institutions,^b that he would quicken, illuminate, and renew the unregenerate, and deliver, from their hearts of stone, those who need regeneration, &c.^c Nor need any suspect that in all this, they talk only to the deaf, or knock at the doors of the dead; since, (1) By doing what belongs to them, leaving the success to God, they perform their *bounden* duty and will deliver their own souls.^d (2) Altho' it may so happen that they are treating with those, who are *spiritually* dead; yet they are treating with those who are *naturally* alive, who are endowed with understanding and will, and can understand things in their grammatical and historical sense. (3) Because God, in the use of such means, is wont to bestow the grace of regeneration.^e

XXXIX. *Seventhly.* This subject may serve to ex-
 port the regenerate, diligently to apply to the duties
 meet for regeneration; viz. (1.) That they acknow-
 ledge the unspeakable *grace* of God, bestowed on them
 in regeneration, by his mere *good pleasure*, while so
 many thousands are passed by; and that they rejoice
 therein.^a (2.) That sensible of this unspeakable bene-
 fit, they are abundant in ingenuous *thanksgiving* to
 God.^b (3.) That they wholly *depend* on God, as the
 original fountain of their spiritual life;^c who worketh
 in us, both to will, and to do.^d (4.) That in the use
 of appointed means, they strive for a continual *increase*
 of the spiritual life, communicated to them by rege-
 neration.^e (5.) For this end, they should be importu-
 nate with God, in fervent prayer.^f (6.) Especially
 should they endeavour with all engagedness to bring
 forth into the *second acts* (or exercises) the *first act* of
 spiritual life which they received by regeneration; as
 they, who *live* by the spirit, should also *walk* in the
 spirit;^g and therefore, (7.) Being drawn, they should
 run;^h being delivered from the heart of stone, they
 should *make* to themselves a new heart, and a new spi-
 rit;ⁱ being circumcised, they should *circumcise* themselves
 to the Lord, and take away more and more the *foreskin* of
 their heart.^k h. e. Being now made alive by regenera-
 tion, they should put off, by *conversion* and repentance,
 concerning their former *conversation*, the old man, and be
 renewed in the spirit of their mind; and that they might
 put on the new man which after God is created in righteouf-
 ness and true holiness.^l And that they bear in mind that
 they are, by regeneration, the *workmanship* of God, cre-
 ated in Christ Jesus unto good works, that they might walk
 in them.^m But these things belong to *conversion* and
sanctification, which are the end of regeneration, as the
second acts (or exercises) are the end of the *first act* or
 principle.

7 This sub-
 ject recom-
 mends to the
 regenerate,
 that they ap-
 ply diligent-
 ly to the du-
 ties meet for
 regeneration.
 What they
 are.

^a James 1. 17.
 18. Eph. 2. 5.
 6. compared
 with Luke

15. 32.

^b 1 Pet. 1. 3. 4.

^c 2 Cor. 4. 4.

5 6.

^d Phil. 2. 13.

^e 1 Pet. 2. 2.

^f Ps 51. 12.

^g Gal. 5. 25.

Rom. 8. 1:

^h Cant. 1. 4.

ⁱ Ezek 18 31.

^k Jer. 4. 4.

^l Eph. 4. 22.

^m 23. 24.

ⁿ Eph. 2. 10.

APPENDIX.

FROM the Westminster confession of faith, chap. 10. of effectual calling. "All those whom God hath predestinated unto life, and those only, he is pleased in his appointed and accepted time, effectually to call by his word and Spirit, out of that state of sin and death, in which they are by nature, to grace and salvation by Jesus Christ; enlightening their minds; spiritually and savingly to understand the things of God; taking away their heart of stone, and giving unto them an heart of flesh; renewing their wills, and by his *almighty power determining them to* that which is good; and effectually drawing them to Jesus Christ; yet so as they come most freely, being made willing by his grace.

II. This effectual call is of God's free and special grace alone, not from any thing at all foreseen in man, who is altogether *passive* therein, until being quickened and renewed by the Holy Spirit, he is thereby enabled to answer this call, and to embrace the grace offered and conveyed in it."

Dr. Twiss Prolocutor of the assembly of divines at Westminster in his *Vindiciæ Gratiæ*, &c. page 15. of the preface, thus defines efficacious grace. "We explain efficacious grace to be an Operation of God affecting the will of man, which is not moral but *physical*, that is immediately and really working in us to do whatsoever good we perform, determining the will to action, but yet so as that it acts freely."

Part III. Page 124. "We do not deny that God acts by (moral) suasion; but he acts also by a *physical* operation, which immediately and immutably affects the

the will and that by an irresistible agency : For as to moral suasion, it is plain the agent acts only in the way of placing objects before the mind, which neither acts upon the will immediately, nor at all after the manner of an efficient cause, but merely after the manner of a final cause. This divine concurrence is of that kind that neither men nor angels can resist. We say this action of God cannot be resisted, for this reason, that it doth not consist in moral suasion, so as to be in its nature resistible ; but in an immediate change of the will, which cannot properly be called either resistible or irresistible with respect to the will upon which it acts : For that, properly speaking, is irresistible, which a person *can not* resist tho' he *wills* to. But supposing a man should will otherwise, than God worketh in him to will, he not only *could* resist, but herein actually *would* resist : But upon this supposition it would follow, that God did not work in him by changing his will ; for if he changed his will, hereby of unwilling he would make him willing. But if we suppose a man to will any thing from the operation of God, it cannot be that he should not will it or will the contrary. For God himself cannot make a thing to be and not to be at the same time."

Dr. Ridgley, in his exposition of the larger catechism under the answer, which treats of effectual calling, Vol. 2. P. 20. gives his sentiments upon the doctrine of regeneration in the following words.

"The first step that he (i. e. God) is pleased to take in this work, (i. e. the work of effectual calling) is in his implanting a principle of spiritual life and grace, which is absolutely necessary for our attaining to, or receiving advantage by the external call of the gospel ; this is generally stiled regeneration, or the new birth ; or, as in the scripture but now referred to, (viz. Ezek. 36. 26.) *a new heart*. If it be enquired, What we are to understand by this principle ? We answer, That since principles are only known by those effects they produce,

springs of acting, by the actions themselves, we must be content with this description ; that it is something wrought in the heart of man, whereby he is habitually and prevailingly biassed and inclined to what is good : So that by virtue hereof, he freely, readily, and willingly chooses those things which tend to the glory of God ; and refuses, abhors and flees from what is contrary thereunto ; and, as this more immediately affects the understanding, whereby it is enabled to discern the things which God reveals in the gospel in a spiritual way, it is stiled, *his shining in the heart, to give us the light of the knowledge of his glory, or his giving an eye to see, and an ear to hear.* As it respects the will, it contains in it a power, whereby it is disposed, and enabled to yield the obedience of faith, to what ever God is pleased to reveal to us as a rule of duty, so that we are made willing in the day of his power ; and as it respects the affections, they are all disposed to run in a right channel, to desire, delight and rejoice in every thing that is pleasing to God, and flee from ever thing that is provoking to him. This is that whereby a dead sinner is made alive, and so enabled to put forth living actions.

Concerning this principle of grace, let it be observed, that it is infused, and not acquired. The first principle or spring of good actions, may, with equal reason, be supposed to be infused into us as Christians, as it is undoubtedly true, that the principle of reasoning is infused into us as men : None ever supposed that the natural power of reasoning may be acquired, tho' a greater facility or degree thereof is gradually attained ; so that power, whereby we are enabled to put forth supernatural acts of grace, which we call a principle of grace, must be supposed to be implanted in us ; which, were it acquired, we could not, properly speaking, be said to be born of God.

From hence I am obliged to infer, that the regenerating act, or implanting this principle of grace, which is,

at least, in order of nature, antecedent to any act of grace, put forth by us, is the immediate effect of the power of God, which none, who speak of regeneration as a divine work, pretend to deny ; and therefore I cannot but conclude, that it is wrought in us *without the instrumentality of the word, or any of the ordinary means of grace* : My reason for it is this ; because it is necessary (from the nature of the thing) to our receiving, improving or reaping any saving advantage by the word, that the spirit should produce the principle of faith ; and to say, that this ~~is~~ done by the word, is, in effect, to assert that the word produces the principle, and the principle gives efficacy to the word ; which seems to me little less than arguing in a circle. The word cannot profit unless it be mixed with faith ; and faith cannot be put forth, unless it proceeds from a principle of grace implanted ; therefore this principle of grace is not produced by it : We may as well suppose, that the presenting a beautiful picture before a man that is blind, can enable him to see ; or the violent motion of a withered hand, produce strength for action, as we can suppose that the presenting the word, in an objective way, is the instrument whereby God produces that internal principle, by which we are enabled to embrace it. Neither would this so well agree with the *idea* of its being a new creature ; or our being *created unto good works* ; for then it ought rather to be said, we are created by faith, which is a good work : This is, in effect, to say that the principle of grace is produced by the instrumentality of that which supposes its being implanted, and is the result and consequence thereof.

I am sorry that I am obliged in this assertion, to appear, at least, to oppose what has been maintained by many divines of great worth ; who have in all other respects, explained the doctrine of regeneration, agreeably to the mind and will of God, and the analogy of faith. It may be the principal difference between this
 explication,

explication, and their's is, that they speak of regeneration in a large sense, as including in it, not barely the implanting the principle, but the exciting it, and do not sufficiently distinguish between the principle as implanted and deduced into act ; for, I readily own, that the latter is, by the instrumentality of the word, though I cannot think the former so ; or, it may be, they consider the principle as excited ; whereas I consider it as created, or wrought in us ; and therefore can no more conclude that the new creation is wrought by an instrument, than I can, that the first creation of all things was.

And I am ready to conjecture, that that which leads many divines into this way of thinking, is the sense in which they understand the words of the apostle : *Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God which liveth and abideth forever* : And elsewhere, *Of his own will, begat he us with the word of truth, that we should be a kind of first-fruits of his creatures*. Whereas this doth not so much respect the implanting the principle of grace, as it does our being enabled to act from that principle ; and 'tis as tho' he should say, he hath made us believers, or induced us to love and obey him by the word of truth, which supposes a principle of grace to have been implanted ; otherwise the word of truth would never have produced these effects. Regeneration may be taken, not only for our being made alive to God, or created unto good works, but for our putting forth living actions, proceeding from that principle which is implanted in the soul. I am far from denying, that faith, and all other graces are wrought in us by the instrumentality of the word ; and it is in this sense that some, who treat on this subject, explain their sentiments, when they speak of being born again by the word : Therefore I persuade myself, that I differ from them only in the acceptation of words, and not in the main substance of the doctrine they maintain."

Doct. Ridgley quotes Charnock, with approbation, concerning

concerning the distinction between regeneration and conversion, in the following words. "Regeneration is a spiritual change ; conversion is a spiritual motion ; in regeneration there is a power conferred ; conversion is the exercise of this power ; in regeneration there is given us a principle to turn ; conversion is our actual turning ; in the covenant, the new heart, and God's putting the spirit into them, is distinguished from their walking in his statutes, from the first step we take in the way of God, and is set down as the cause of our motion : In renewing us God gives us a power ; in converting us he excites that power. Men are naturally dead, and have a stone upon them ; regeneration is a rolling away the stone from the heart, and a raising to newness of life ; and then conversion is as natural to a regenerate man, as motion is to a living body : A principle of activity will produce action. The first reviving us is wholly the act of God, without any concurrence of the creature ; but, after we are revived, we do actively and voluntarily, live in his sight. Regeneration is the motion of God in the creature ; conversion is the motion of the creature to God, by virtue of that first principle ; from this principle all the acts of believing, repenting, mortifying, quickening do spring. In all these a man is active ; in the other he is merely passive."*

Thus far Mr. Charnock.

Doct. Ridgley further observes, (vol. 2. p. 23) relative to our passivity in regeneration. "I cannot but take notice of a question which frequently occurs under this head, viz. Whether man in the first moment thereof, viz. in regeneration, be merely passive, tho' active in every thing that follows after it ? This we cannot but affirm, not only against the *Pelagians*, but others, whose method of treating the doctrine of divine grace, seems to agree with theirs. This is sufficiently evident, not only from the impotency of corrupt nature, as to what is good, but it's utter averseness thereto, and from the

* See Charnock on regeneration, Vol. 2. page 70, 71.

the work's being truly and properly divine; or (as has been before observed) the effect of almighty power. *This is not a controversy of late date*; but has been either defended or opposed, ever since *Augustine's* and *Pelagius's* time."

With respect to preparatory works, Doct. Ridgely seems well to agree with Van Mastricht. Upon this point he quotes Mr. Charnock, in the following words. "Man cannot prepare himself for the new birth: He hath indeed a subjective capacity for grace, above any other creature in the inferior world; and this is a kind of natural preparation, which other creatures have not; a capacity, in regard of the powers of the soul, tho' not in respect of the present disposition of them. He hath an understanding to know, and when it is enlightened to know God's law; a will to move and run, and when enlarged by grace, to run in the ways of God's commandments; so that he stands in an immediate capacity to receive the life of grace, upon the breath and touch of God, which a stone doth not; for in this it is necessary, that rational faculties should be put as a foundation of spiritual motions. Tho' the soul be thus capable, as a subject, to receive the grace of God, yet it is not therefore capable as an agent, to prepare itself for it, or produce it. It is capable to receive the truths of God; but as the heart is stony, it is incapable to receive the impressions of those truths.

Charnock on regeneration. Vol. 2. p. 147, 148.

Mr. Willard, one of the most noted New-England divines, in his Exposition upon the lesser catechism, under the answer which respects effectual calling, p. 433, 434, thus observes,

"1. There is something habitually wrought in the man, whereby he is capacitated and disposed to believe in Christ. And this is usually called *passive conversion*.
2. There is something done *actually*, by the man in the exciting of this power so created in him, in which he applies

applies those graces or powers in him, to their objects, and exerciseth them ; and particularly his faith, in closing with, and embracing of Jesus Christ exhibited in the promise ; and is in the gospel called believing.—Again, he says, The *act* of faith doth necessarily suppose the *habit* of it, or the power of believing. All acts require a power suitable and sufficient for them ; nor can any agent go beyond its ability : No effect can exceed the virtue of its cause : so that a man must have faith, in order to his exerting it.

Again. There is no *co-operation* of the man with the spirit in the producing of the habit of faith in him. He is a subject but not an agent. He contributes nothing at all to it, but it is wholly put into him by another hand. It is a *creating work*, and that belongs to God alone. Eph. 2. 10. It is a resurrection, and that belongs entirely to the divine Omnipotency. Eph. 1. 19. It is a *regeneration*, and none ever helped to beget himself, yea, being a *spiritual regeneration*, none but the spirit can effect it.

The means themselves have no efficacy in the production of this habit by moral suasion. Not but that the spirit useth the means in order to his bringing about this work in us. *Ezekiel* was to prophesy in order to the dry bones living. Ezek. 37. 9, 10. The means are properly accommodated to work on man as a moral agent, rationally, by evidence or demonstration, by convictions, awakenings, encouragements, and the spirit comes with them as he sees meet, and gives them such an operation : But either their operation is common, and that can at most be but preparatory ; or it is saving, and then it suppoeth this habit in them. Moral suasion can do only on a subject capable. Come to the grave of a dead man, and make never so grave an oration to him, tell him what a miserable condition a state of death is, and what benefits accompany the living, and so beg of him to rise and live ; And what will this do ? There must be faith, to receive Christ, e'er the endeavours to persuade men produce
the

the act of believing on him, *and this is an operation more than merely ethical or moral.*"

Page 435. "All the orthodox consent, that there must be a *new power* put into the man in order to his believing in Christ. That a man can no more of himself come up to the terms of the new covenant, than keep the law of the first covenant. They that deny this are unacquainted with the efficacy of the apostacy, or energy of *original sin* in man. Philosophy tells us that live actions require life in the agent. And spiritual actions must derive from a spiritual life; gracious actions must flow from grace. Call this an habit or a virtue, or a principle; it must be an ability to do these things, which it had not naturally, but must be given it.

This power or ability can be produced by no other, but the Spirit of God. And that because it requires Omnipotency, to the producing of it; and there is none almighty but he. None but he that could make a world, bring light out of darkness, raise the dead, can do this. — Indeed the Spirit of God in these works find only Impotency in the subject but no resistance; whereas here he meets with, not only a total debility in the creature to join with him in it, but also a malignant opposition to it; there being nothing which the heart of man is more averse to, than coming to Christ and believing in him."

Page 442. As to the necessity of (a legal) conviction or preparation, he thus observes. "This conviction hath no causal influence unto passive conversion. All the necessity that can be urged on that account, is only that of *concomitancy*. The Spirit of God hath done this in such as were not capable of conviction under and by the means. Judicious divines judge that *Jeremiah* and *John the Baptist* were converted before they were born. And it is to be believed that elect infants dying in their infancy, have the new creature formed in them. without which they could not be saved. John 3. 3. *Verily, verily I say*

unto

unto thee, except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God. And possibly this work is done for others that live, before we are aware of it, who have given evidence of their seriousness from their infancy. However, the man can no more convert himself upon these convictions, than he could before, nor is it easier for the spirit to do it now. Whenever it is done, it must be a creating power, in which God useth *no instrument, but acts immediately.*"

Page 455. There must be a *renewing change* wrought in the *will*, in order to its being enabled to close with Christ. Could we suppose never so much light let into the understanding, causing it to discern all the preciousness of Christ as he is revealed in the gospel; yet if the will remain in the same posture it is, in the man's natural estate, it would be impossible for it to chuse Christ, and to love him. There must therefore be a renovation on it. When therefore the apostle had spoken of our being *renewed in the image of our mind*, Eph. 4. 23. he exemplifies it with respect to the will; vers. 24. *And that ye put on the new man, which after God is created in righteousness, and true holiness.* A new understanding, without a new heart, will never amount to a thorough conversion. As long as the will remains possessed of corrupt lusts, and hath no power in it, it can never embrace Christ.

This renewing change is wrought, by *creating* a new principle of saving grace in the *will* and *affections*. It is certain that if ever the man believe, he must have power to believe. This power is that which we call the habit of faith; which habit is not infused by itself, but together with all the other regenerating graces, which are wrought in the soul by the Spirit. This is that which is called the giving of a new heart, and the putting in of a new spirit, &c. Ezek. 36. 26. Which cannot intend new faculties, but a new saving impression of grace on the faculties of the soul in the man.

Mr. Flavel asserts the *priority* of the work of regeneration to faith in Christ, in the following words.

“For look as the blood of Christ is the fountain of all merit, so the Spirit of Christ is the fountain of all spiritual life. And until he quicken us, (i. e.) infuse the principle of divine life into our souls, we can put forth no hand, or vital act of faith, to lay hold upon Jesus Christ.—This his quickening work, is therefore the *first* in order of nature to our union with Christ, and *fundamental* to all other acts of grace done and performed by us, from our first closing with Christ, throughout the whole course of our obedience.” *Method of grace, ser. 5.*

Mr. Flavel’s first head in the same discourse is, “Briefly to represent the necessary *antecedency* of this quickening work of the Spirit, to our *first* closing with Christ by faith. This, (he says) will easily let itself into your understanding, if you will but consider the nature of the vital act of faith ; which is the soul’s receiving of Christ, and resting upon him for pardon and salvation.”

After having insisted upon this *antecedency* of regeneration to faith, he starts this *question*, and gives the following *solution*.

“*Quest.* But here it may be doubted, and objected against this position. If we cannot believe till we are quickened with spiritual life, as you say, and cannot be justified till we believe, as all say, then it will follow, that a regenerate soul may be in state of condemnation for a time and consequently perish, if death should befall him in that juncture.”

“*Sol.* To this I return ; That when we speak of the *priority* of this quickening work of the Spirit to our actual believing, we rather understand it of the priority of *nature*, than of *time*, the nature and order of the work requiring it to be so ; a vital principle must, in order of nature be infused, *before* a vital act can be exerted. First make the tree good, and then the fruit good : And admit we should grant some priority in *time* also to this quickening

quickenings principle, before actual faith ; yet the absurdity mentioned would be no way consequent upon this concession : For as the vital act of faith quickly follows the regenerating principle, so the soul is abundantly secured against the danger objected ; God never beginning any special work of grace upon the soul, and then leaving it, and the soul with it, in hazard ; but preserves both to the finishing and compleating of his gracious design, Phil. 1. 6." *Ibid.*

The same author abundantly asserts, that regeneration is a *supernatural* effect, produced by the exertion of *almighty power*, and that we are therein *wholly passive*. His very doctrine in the above mentioned discourse is this ; " That those souls, which have union with Christ, are quickened with a *supernatural* principle of life by the Spirit of God *in order thereunto*."

Again, " As it is said of the two witnesses, Rev. xi. 11. Who lay dead in a civil sense, three days and an half, that the spirit of life from God entered into them ; so it is here in a spiritual sense, the spirit of life from God enters into the dead, carnal heart : it is all by way of *supernatural infusion*."—*Ibid.*

Again. "In the next place, according to the method proposed, I am obliged to shew you, that this quickening work is *wholly supernatural* ; it is the *sole* and *proper* work of the spirit of God. So Christ himself expressly asserts it, in Joh. 3. 6, 8. *That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the spirit, is spirit* : the wind bloweth where it listeth, and thou hearest the sound thereof, but canst not tell whence it cometh, nor whither it goeth, so is every one that is born of the spirit. Believers are the birth, or offspring of the spirit, who produceth the new creature in them in an unintelligible manner even to themselves. So far is it *above their own ability to produce*, that it is above their capacity to understand the way of its production.—We can *contribute nothing*, I mean *actively*, to the production of this principle

principle of life. We may indeed be said to concur *passively*, with the spirit in it ; that is, there is found in us a capacity, aptness or *receptiveness* of this principle of life. Our nature is endowed with such faculties and powers as are meet subjects to receive, and instruments to act this spiritual life : God only quickens the rational nature with spiritual life."

" It is true also, that in the *progress* of sanctification, a man doth actively concur with the spirit ; but in the *production* of this principle he *can do nothing* ; he can indeed perform those external duties that have a remote tendency to it, but he cannot by the power of nature perform any saving act, or contribute any thing more than a *passive* capacity to the implantation of a new principle : as will appear by the following arguments."

" Arg. 1. He that *actively* concurs to his own regeneration, makes himself to differ ; but this is denied to all regenerate men, 1 Cor. iv. 7. *Who maketh thee to differ from another ? And what hast thou, that thou didst not receive ?*"

" Arg. 2. That to which the scripture ascribes both impotency and enmity with respect to grace, cannot *actively*, and of itself concur to the production of it : but the scripture ascribes both impotency and enmity to nature, with respect to grace. It denies to it a power to *do any thing* of itself, John xv. 5. And which is less, it denies to it a power to speak a good word, Mat. xii. 34. And which is least of all, it denies it power to *think a good thought*. 2 Cor. iii. 5. This impotency, if there were no more, cuts off all pretence of our *active* concurrence. But then, if we consider that it ascribes enmity to our natures, as well as impotency, how clear is the case ! See Rom. viii. 7. *The carnal mind is ENMITY against God*. And Col. i. 21. *And you that were ENEMIES in your minds by wicked works*. So then nature is so far productive of this principle, as impotency and enmity can enable it to *be so*."

" Arg.

“ Arg. 3. That which is of natural production must needs be subject to natural dissolution. That which is born of the flesh, is flesh ; a perishing thing ; for every thing is as its principle is, and there can be no more in the effect than there is in the cause. But this principle of spiritual life is not subject to dissolution. It is the water which springs up into everlasting life, John iv. 14. The seed of God which remaineth in the regenerate, 1 John iii. 9. And all because it is born not of corruptible, but incorruptible seed, 1 Pet. i. 23.”

“ Arg. 4. If our new birth be our resurrection, a new creation, yea a victory of our nature, then we cannot *actively* contribute to its production. But under all these notions it is represented to us in the scriptures. It is our resurrection from the dead, Eph. v. 14. And you know the body is *wholly passive* in its resurrection. But tho’ it concurs not, yet it gives pre-existent matter. Therefore the metaphor is designedly varied, Eph. iv. 24. Where it is called a *creation* ; in which there is neither active concurrence nor pre-existent matter. But tho’ creation excludes pre-existent matter, yet in producing something out of nothing, there is no reluctancy or opposition. Therefore to show how purely *supernatural* this principle of life is, it is cloathed and represented to us in the notion of a *victory*, 2 Cor. x 23. And so leaves all to grace.”

“ Arg. 5. If nature could *produce*, or *actively concur* to the production of this *supernatural* life, then the best natures would be soonest quickened with it ; and the worst natures not at all, or at last, and least of all. But contrarily, we find the worst natures often regenerated, and the best left in the state of spiritual death. With how many sweet *homiletical* virtues was the young man adorned ? Mark x. 21. yet graceless ; and what a sink of sin was *Mary Magdalen*, Luke vii. 37. Yet sanctified. Thus beautiful Rachel is barren, while Leah bears children. And there is scarce any thing that affects and melts

melts the hearts of Christians more, than this comparative consideration doth, when they consider vessels of gold cast away, and leaden ones chosen for such noble uses. So that it is plain enough to all wise and humble souls, that this new life is *wholly of supernatural production.*—*Ibid.*

Again. “But though we cannot pry into these secrets by the eye of reason, yet God hath revealed this to us in his word, that it is wrought by *his own almighty power*, Eph. i. 19. The apostle ascribes this work to the *exceeding greatness of the power of God*. And this must needs be, if we consider, how the spirit of God expresses it in scripture by a new creation; (i. e.) a giving being to something, out of nothing, Eph. 2. 10. In this it differs from all the effects of human power; for men always work upon some pre-existent matter, but here there is no such matter. All that is in man, the subject of this work, is only a *passive* capacity, or *receptivity*, but nothing is found in him to *contribute* towards this work. This *supernatural* life is not, nor can be educed out of natural principles. This *wholly transcends the sphere of all natural power.*—*Ibid.*

The testimony of this author is also very express, that regeneration is effected *instantaneously*. His words are these, “This infusion of spiritual life is done *instantaneously*, as all *creation*-work is. Hence it is resembled to that *plastic power*, which in a moment made the light to shine out of darkness; just to God shines into our hearts, 2 Cor. iv. 6.”

“It is true, a soul may be a long time under the preparatory work of the spirit; he may be under convictions and humiliations, purposes and resolutions a long time,—attending the means and ordinances; but when the spirit comes to quicken the soul, it is done *in a moment*: even as it is in the infusion of the rational soul, the body is long e’re it is prepared and moulded, but when once prepared and ready, it is quickened with the spirit of life in an INSTANT.” *Ibid.* Doct.

Doct. Wits or Witſius, a noted Dutch divine of the laſt age, ſometime colleague with *Van Maſtricht* in the Profeſſorſhip at Utrecht, afterwards Regent of the Divinity College of the Sates of Holland and Weſt-Frieſland, in his *Æconomy of the Covenants* under the head of Eſſectual Calling, Page 471 of Dr. Crookſhank's tranſlation, thus obſerves,

“ The *external* call will bring none to communion with Chriſt, unleſs it be accompanied with the *internal*, which is accompliſhed not only by perſuaſion and command, but by the powerful operation of the Spirit. There is a certain call of God, whereby he makes the things, he calls, to exiſt, by that very call. By ſuch a call, *he calleth thoſe things which be not, as though they were.* Rom. 4. 17. For, when he ſaid, let there be light, immediately there was light, Gen. 1. 3. Not unlike this is that internal call of the ſpirit, of which the apoſtle writes, 2 Cor. 4. 6. *God who commanded the light to ſhine out of darkneſs, hath ſhined in our hearts.*

Here God exerts his infinite power, by which he converts the ſoul no leſs powerfully than ſweetly. He writes his law on their heart, Jer. 31. 33. Puts the reverence of himſelf there, Ezek. 11. 20. And not only calls them from darkneſs to his marvellous light; but alſo, by the call, *draws* them, not to ſtand ſtill in the path of doubtful deliberation, but to *run after him*, Cant. 1. 4. Not only puts them in an equal poſe, but turns them. Jer. 31. 18. Not only adviſes, but perſuades, and *he is ſtronger and prevails*, Jer. 20. 7. Nor does he ſollicit, but *translate*, Col. 1. 13. Not by an ordinary, but by that mighty power, by which he raiſed Chriſt from the dead. Eph. 1. 20.”

Under the head of regeneration, p. 476. he gives this definition of it, “ REGENERATION is that *ſupernatural act* of God, whereby a new and divine life is inſuſed into the elect perſon, ſpiritually dead, and that from the incorruptible ſeed of the word of God, made fruitful by the infinite power of the Spirit.

Spirit. * He then observes upon the spiritual death of sinners, "that they are spiritually insensible of all spiritual things, and destitute of all true feeling;—nor have they any relish for divine grace, because it has not yet been conferred upon them; nor any longing after heavenly things, being ignorant of their worth. They are wholly incapable of every act of true life.—The understanding is overspread with dismal darkness. The will has no tendency to things unknown: and thus all the things of God are despised by it as mean." Page 478. "By regeneration a new life is put into the elect, resulting from a gracious union with God and his Spirit. For, what the soul is to the body, that God is to the soul. Moreover, this spiritual life may be considered, either by way of *faculty*, and in the *first act*, in the usual language of the schools; or by way of *operation*, and in the *second act*. In the former respect, it is that *inward constitution* of the soul, whereby it is fitted to exert those actions, which are acceptable to God in Christ, by the power of the spirit uniting it to God: whether such actions immediately flow from that principle, or whether they lie concealed for some time, as fruits in their seed. In the latter respect, it is that activity of the living soul, by which it acts agreeably to the command of God, and the example of Christ.

If we consider this first principle of life, there is not the least doubt, but regeneration is accomplished in a moment. For there is no delay in the transition from death to life. No intermediate state between the regenerate and unregenerate can be imagined so much as in thought, if we mean regeneration in the first act: for one

* Doct. *Wissius* probably intends the same kind of instrumentality of the word as Doct. *Van Mastricht*, when he calls it "*only a moral instrument* of regeneration," and that not so properly to regeneration in the first act, (which seems to consist, according to these authors, in fructifying or making fruitful the word, or rather in laying a foundation for the words becoming fruitful, in which the word cannot be an instrument) as to regeneration in the second act or consequent exercises; see extracts from Doct. Ridgley.

one is either dead or alive : either the child of God, or of the devil ; either in the way to salvation or damnation. There neither is, nor can be any medium here.

Hence it appears, there are no preparations antecedent to the first beginning of regeneration ; because previous to that, nothing but mere death in the highest degree is to be found in the person to be regenerated. *When we were DEAD IN SINS*, he hath quickened us together with Christ, Eph. 2. 5. And indeed the scripture represents man's conversion by such similitudes, as show, that all preparations are entirely excluded ; sometimes calling it a *new Generation* to which, certainly, none can contribute any thing of himself : But yet, as natural generation presupposes some dispositions in the matter ; so, that we may not imagine any such thing to be in ourselves but from God, we have this held forth by the similitude of a *resurrection* ; in which a body is restored from matter, prepared by no qualifications : yet because here, certainly is matter, but in the resurrection of the soul there is nothing at all, therefore we have added the figure of a *creation*, Pl. 51. 10. Eph. 2. 10. By which we are taught, that a new creature exists from a spiritual nothing, which is sin ; but as there was not something in nothing, to assist and sustain creation ; so there was nothing to oppose and resist ; but sin is so far from submitting to what God does, that it is reluctant thereto, and in an hostile manner at enmity with him : accordingly the other images did not fully complete the idea of this admirable action, till at length it is called the *victory* of God : Victory, I say, over the devil who maintains his palace, Luke 11. 21, and effectually worketh in the children of disobedience, Eph. 2. 2. All these operations of God tend to exclude, as much as possible, all preparations from the beginning of our regeneration."

He then goes on to censure the *Semi-pelagians* of Merseilles, " who insisted that a man comes to the grace whereby we are regenerated in Christ, by a natural fa-

culty ; as by asking, seeking, knocking, and that, in some at least, before they are born again, there is a kind of repentance going before, together with a sorrow for sin, and a change of life for the better, and a beginning of faith, and an initial love of God, and a desire of grace. And tho' they did not look on these endeavours to be of such importance, as that it could be said, we were thereby rendered worthy of the grace of the Holy Spirit ; as *Pelagius* and *Julian* professed : Yet they imagined, they were an *occasion* by which God was moved, to bestow his grace." And likewise the *remonstrants*, who write, that "*some work of man goes before his vivification ; namely to acknowledge and bewail his death, to will, and desire deliverance from it ; to hunger, thirst and seek after life.*" He observes " there is little accuracy in the reasonings of these men. For, 1st. Since our nature is become like an evil tree, it can produce no fruit truly good and acceptable to God, and do nothing, by which it can prepare itself for the grace of regeneration. 2dly. It has been found, that they, who, in appearance were, in the best manner disposed for regeneration, were yet at the greatest distance from it, as the instance of that young man, Mark 19. 21, 22, very plainly shews. 3dly. And on the other hand, they, who had not even the least appearance of any preparation, as the publicans and harlots, went into the kingdom of God, before those who were civilly righteous and externally religious. 4thly. God testifies, that in the first approach of his grace, *he is found of them, that sought him not, and asked not for him.* Isa. 65. 1. Fulgentius says extremely well : *We have not certainly received grace, because we are willing, but grace is given us, while we are still unwilling.*"

He then observes, p. 483, upon the preparations which have been admitted by some of the reformed as Perkins, Ames, and the British Divines at the Synod of Dort, " who have assigned in persons to be regenerated, 1st. A breaking off the natural obstinacy, and a flexibility

lity of the will. 2. A serious consideration of the law. 3. A consideration of their own sins and offences against God. 4. A legal fear of punishment, and a dread of hell, and consequently a despairing of their salvation, with respect to any thing in themselves." These, he acknowledges, differ from the favourers of *Pelagianism* in the following manner, 1st. That they are not for having these things to proceed from nature, but profess them to be the effects of the spirit of bondage, preparing a way to himself, for their actual regeneration. 2dly. That they are not for God's bestowing the grace of regeneration from a regard to, and moved by occasion of, these preparations, much less by any merit in them; but they imagine that God, in this manner, levels a way for himself, fills up vallies, depresses mountains and hills, in order the better to smooth the way for his entrance into that soul." Upon which he observes, "We really think they argue more accurately, who make these and the like things in the elect, to be preparations to the further and more perfect operations of a more noble and plentiful spirit, and so not preparations for regeneration, but the fruits and effects of the first regeneration: For as these things suppose some life of the soul, which spiritually attends to spiritual things, and are operations of the spirit of God; when going about to sanctify the elect; we cannot but refer them to the spirit of grace and regeneration."

P. 485. If this matter be more closely considered, we shall find, that the orthodox differ more in words, and in the manner of explaining, than in sense and reality. For, the term, regeneration, is of ambiguous signification; sometimes it is blended with sanctification, and by regeneration is understood that action of God, whereby man, who is now become the friend of God, and endowed with spiritual life, acts in a righteous and holy manner, from infused habits. And then it is certain, there are some effects of the spirit, by which he usually prepares

pare them for the actings of complete faith and holiness ; for, a knowledge of divine truths, a sense of misery, sorrow for sin, hope of pardon, &c. go before any one can fiducially lay hold on Christ, and apply himself to the practice of true godliness.—But sometimes regeneration denotes the first translation of a man from a state of death, to a state of spiritual life ; in which sense we take it. And in that sense none of the orthodox, if he will speak consistently with his own principles, can suppose preparatory works to the grace of regeneration.”

P. 489. “ After a principle of spiritual life is infused into the elect soul by regeneration, divine grace does not always proceed therein, in the same method and order. It is possible that for some time, the spirit of the life of Christ may lie, as it were dormant in some (almost in the same manner, as vegetative life in the seed of a plant, or sensitive life in the seed of an animal, or a poetical genius in one born a poet) so as that no vital operations can yet proceed therefrom, tho’ savingly united to Christ, the fountain of true life by the spirit. This is the case with respect to elect and regenerate infants, whose is the kingdom of God, and who therefore are reckoned among believers and saints, tho’ unqualified thro’ age, actually to believe and practise godliness.”

Doct. Le Blanc, a noted divine of the Reformed Church in France in the last century, tho’ perhaps not entirely friendly himself to the sentiments which *Van Mastricht* has advanced upon the subject of regeneration and efficacious grace ; yet *allows* the general sentiments of the reformed church to be such as are conformable to his, as the following extracts shew. In the *Thesis* concerning the distinction between sufficient and efficacious grace among protestants : After giving the sentiments of the Lutherans and Remonstrants, and observing that the Reformed generally renounce the distinction, he thus further explains their sentiments concerning divine grace.

Page 13. " It is the common opinion of all the Reformed who adhere to the synod of Dort, that the grace of God, to which is to be ascribed the conversion of man and all the good works which follow thereupon, is effectual of *itself*; nor doth its efficacy in any measure depend upon the co-operation or consent of the will of man; since it is the infallible cause of that consent or co-operation. And this is agreeable to the decrees of the Synod of Dort. For that Synod condemn those, who teach *that God, in the work of regeneration, doth not put forth his almighty power, whereby he powerfully and infallibly determineth the will to faith and conversion: but that, supposing all the operations of grace, which God useth in conversion, man can so resist God and the Spirit, when designing and willing to regenerate him, and oft times actually doth so resist, as utterly to hinder his regeneration; and that therefore it remains in the power of man, whether to be regenerated or not.* They also condemn those who teach, *that grace and free will are joint causes concurring together in the beginning of conversion, and that grace in the order of nature doth not precede the efficiency of the will: that is, that God doth not efficaciously assist the will of man to conversion, before the will of man moveth and determineth itself.* And how God effecteth a real conversion in the elect, the same Synod thus explaineth. *He not only causeth the gospel to be externally preached unto them and powerfully illuminateth their minds by the Holy Ghost, so as rightly to understand and discern the things of the Spirit of God; but by the efficacy of the same Spirit, in his regenerating influences, He penetrateth the inmost recesses of the soul; openeth their closed hearts; softeneth their hard hearts; circumciseth their uncircumcised hearts; infuseth new qualites into the will; and of dead, maketh it alive; of evil, maketh it good; of unwilling, maketh it willing; of disobedient, obedient; and leadeth and strengthneth it; so that it is enabled, like a good tree, to bring forth fruit in good actions.* And in the next article they add, *this operation of God is entirely supernatural, also most powerful and pleasant,*
wonderful,

wonderful, secret, and ineffable ; not less than, or inferior to, the power exerted in creation, or the resurrection of the dead ; so that all they, in whose hearts God worketh in this wonderful manner, are certainly, infallibly, and effectually regenerated and converted."

Page 15. "Altho' the divines of the Reformed Church agree in this, that grace worketh effectually, not only upon the understanding, but also upon the will of man, and that the will is powerfully and infallibly turned and determined thereby to that which is good ; yet there is some difference among them, about the *manner* in which grace affecteth the will ; so that in consequence thereof it should turn to God, and consent to that which is good."

He then speaks of several, as *Testard*, *Amyrald* and *Cameron*, who suppose the will always to follow the last dictate of the understanding ; and that the will is changed and renewed by a powerful illumination of the understanding, agreeably to what is observed by *Van Mastricht* concerning *Cameron* and others, § xxvi. "But (saith he) other divines of the Reformed Church hold, that the immediate operation of grace affecteth, not only the understanding, by illuminating of it ; and infusing new light into it ; but also the will, in which it really and *physically* worketh that consent which it yields to the divine commands. This opinion Doct. *Ames* lays down and explains in his *Bellarminus enervatus*, lib. iii^o de *gratia* cap. 3. We hold, saith he, that together with moral suasion there is joined a real efficiency of God, by which a new principle of spiritual life is effectually wrought in the heart of man, and he at the same time excited to put forth the acts of this life. In the same place he fully approves and acknowledges as his, the sentiment of *Didacus Alvares*, which is that God by the assistance of his grace doth *physically* or after the manner of a physical cause, effectually predetermine the will of the creature, so that he infallibly consenteth and co-operateth with God, calling

ling and inviting him. And afterwards using the words of Alvares, he saith, that physically to pre-determine the will is nothing else than truly, efficiently or really to make the will infallibly to co-operate with God."

This same author further observes, p. 19. "That there is a seeming contradiction in the sentiments of the reformed; who universally hold that man freely puts forth the first act of conversion, and yet that he is *merely* passive in the work of regeneration and conversion; for how can the will of man freely put forth the act of conversion, and yet at the same time be merely passive in conversion? Can the will be merely passive, when it is supposed to operate freely?"

"The British divines (he observes) in the acts of the synod of Dort, solve this difficulty, by observing that conversion is to be taken in a two-fold sense; 1st. As it denoteth the immediate work of God in regeneration: 2dly. As it denoteth the action of the man in turning to God, by saving faith and repentance. In the work of regeneration or conversion, taken in the first sense, according to them, man is merely passive, nor is it in the power of the will of man to hinder God thus immediately converting and regenerating: But in conversion, taken in the other sense, the will being influenced by God, is active, and putteth forth those actions, in which our conversion to God consisteth. But conversion, as it denoteth the immediate work of God, they say, is that whereby he regenerateth, and as it were createth anew, by an internal and wonderful operation the souls of his elect, who have been before exercised and prepared by various workings of his grace; infusing into them a quickening spirit, and endowing all the faculties of the soul with new qualities."

Much to the same purpose ('tis observed) was the opinion of the *Hessian* divines, at the same synod, which ge gives us in the following words, "*The will of man, in the reception of supernatural qualities or faculties and power,*
and

and also in the reception of new inclinations, is merely passive : So that the action of the Holy Spirit infusing that supernatural power into the will, & turning & inclining the will effectually & powerfully to faith & conversion, doth not depend upon the will of man or any co-operation or consent of it. But to the acts of faith, love, hope, &c. and all good exercises, a man is not merely passive, but both passive and active, since, being influenced and moved by the previous grace of God, and assisted by his subsequent grace, he is active in the exercises of faith, love, hope and other virtues."

Doct. Ames, professor of divinity in the university of Franaker, in his work entituled *Medulla Theologiae* in the chapter concerning effectual calling, from sect. 20, to 25, thus observes, " The reception of Christ, with respect to man, is either passive or active, Phil. 3. 12. *That I may apprehend that for which also I am apprehended of Christ.* The passive reception of Christ is that, by which a spiritual principle of grace is begotten in the will of man. Eph. 2. 5. *He hath quickened us.* For this grace is the foundation of that relation, wherein we are united to Christ. John 3. 3. *Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.* The will is the most proper and primary subject of this grace, because the conversion of the will is the effectual principle of the conversion of the whole man, Phil. 2. 13. *For it is God that worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure.* An illumination of the mind is not sufficient to produce this effect, because it doth not take away that corruption which is seated in the will, nor doth it communicate thereto, any new supernatural principle, whereby it can convert itself. The will however, with respect to this first reception, is not to be considered either as freely active, nor as irrationally passive ; but as a subject capable of obeying the divine impression, 2 Cor. 4. 6. *For God who commanded the light to shine out of darkness, hath shined in our hearts,*" &c.

Mr.

Mr. Rutherford, a noted Scotch divine of the last century, in his *Exercitationes apologeticae pro gratiâ divinâ*, gives his sentiments relative to the will's following the last dictate of the understanding (which are agreeable to the sentiments of Van Mastricht) in the following words, p. 366.

“ If the last judgment of the understanding necessarily and of itself determined the will, grace would become mere suasion, nor would any internal grace be necessary to cure the will ; to remove the darkness of the mind and instruct it in what it is ignorant of would be sufficient, *which is the grace of Pelagians*. And thus the mind of a reprobate person, by an acquired habit of faith, and by clear objective evidence, might be so taught (as appears to me possible in the present case) as to discern in a proposed act of obedience, 1. The facility. 2. The pleasure. 3. The utility ; and that the will should not in the present case (as it might do) turn the mind to consider, either the difficulty of it, or any other thing, wherein it might appear as disagreeable, and that the will should not turn the mind, from the contemplation of this act, to earthly considerations. In this case a person might believe, without his will's ever being healed, and perform a supernatural act ; nor would there be any need of taking away the heart of stone and putting within us a heart of flesh. Nor do those places of scripture, which are commonly objected here, prove the contrary, as Ps. 9. 10. *And they that know thy name will put their trust in thee*. If this knowledge (say they) did not determine the will, it might be that they that know the name of God would not trust in the LORD. And also John 4. 10. *If thou knewest the gift of God, and who it is that saith unto thee, give me to drink ; thou wouldst have asked of him, and he would have given thee living water*. Now if this knowledge would not determine the will to ask living water of Christ, then the woman might have known the gift of God, and yet not have asked living

water of him ; and so the words of Christ would not have been true. Ans. In such like propositions, there is always understood the physical agency of God, otherwise if it be taken exactly literal, it would follow that a speculative knowledge of the object would be sufficient for the act of faith, without the infusion of a new power ; which no one will pretend."

Doct. *Burman*, professor of divinity in the university of *Utrecht* thus observes, relative to the insufficiency of illumination to renew the will, p. 227, of his *Theologiae Synopsis*, "Sanctification immediately effects the will, which the very learned *Cameron* wrongly denied, asserting that the other faculties of the soul were rectified and perfected by the light of the understanding, that the will is not immediately affected ; but always follows the last dictate of the understanding. Which are wrongly connected together ; since the order and connection of these faculties, or the power and dominion which the understanding exerciseth over the will, is not such, that the will implicitly followeth the signal held up by the understanding. Hence it happens that corruption doth, in some sense, cleave more strongly to the will, or more deeply affects it, than it doth the understanding ; hence the will cannot be excited, or move itself, according to the light of the understanding alone. That the illumination of the understanding is not sufficient, we have full proof daily from those who are reprobate. There must be, over and above the illumination of the understanding, an attention in the will : Which being supposed the inclination of the will followeth the clear perception of the understanding. But this attention is the gift of God, as appears in the case of *Lydia*. Acts 16. 14.

Both *Rutherford* and *Burman* are full in asserting the priority of regeneration to any gracious exercise, our passivity therein, its being a *physical* and not a moral operation, its irresistibility, &c.

Doct. *Braunius* professor of divinity at *Groningen* after
confuting

confuting many false notions of divine grace held by the Papists, Remonstrants, &c. such as that it consists in moral suasion, in an external illumination, &c. he observes, "That the grace of God ought to be conceived of as a new creation."—"That hereby God dispelleth the darkness of the mind, enkindleth the light of truth, softeneth and bendeth the will; yea as it were createth it anew, reproduceth it, and raiseth it from the dead, and powerfully, and sweetly determineth it to good, so that it most freely wills and embraces it."—"Therefore the will of man is merely *passive* in the first moment of the divine operation; is passive in being fashioned by God according to his good pleasure."—"Hence the apostle well observes, that the will of man with respect to the grace of God is as clay in the hands of the potter, from whom it wholly receives it's form." *Doctrina Fiderum.* p. 528. 529, 530.

With respect to an illumination of the understanding's being sufficient for sanctification, he thus observes, "They are wrong, who teach that sanctification consisteth only in the understanding; since it consisteth in the understanding and will together. The understanding can exercise no dominion over the will; but is merely passive in the reception of objects, as they offer themselves: But the will chuseth what it judgeth to be best. The understanding therefore ought to be enlightened, that it may rightly receive objects and propose them to the will. The will must be renewed, that it may chuse the greatest good. Nor doth it follow, from the will's following the last practical judgment, that the understanding only needs to be sanctified, and not the will; since this last practical judgment is the work of the will; for the will judgeth; not the understanding."

'Tis plain our author means by the understanding the simple faculty of perception; and when he excludes judgment from the understanding, he means the practical judgment, or that which respects our practice, and not things merely speculative. In which sense perhaps this opinion, which at first view appears singular, may be not wide from the truth.

To these quotations I will add a few words from Mr. Brine, a late ingenious writer in England. Page 126, of his book, entituled, *A treatise upon various subjects*.

“Regeneration preceeds and may be considered, as the foundation and spring of conversion and sanctification. For that is the principle from which both arise. Grace as a principle of spiritual acts, is first communicated, and from that proceed all acts of a holy spiritual nature, both internal and external. Neither of the latter can be, until the first is wrought. And when that is effected, both the latter certainly follow. In the first we are merely passive, in conversion and sanctification we are active.”

P. 101. “Regeneration is the infusion of a new principle of spiritual life. Naturally men are dead in trespasses and sins, and, therefore, in order to their acting in a holy and spiritual manner, a living holy principle must be communicated to them. Hence the saints are said to be quickened, that is to say, they are inspired with life. And this is a new life, and is a spring of new actions. It is called a new heart, and a new spirit, and a heart of flesh; grace is not our old nature made better, and excited unto spiritual acts; but it is a new nature produced in our minds, by the infinite power and grace of God. For which reason we are said to be new creatures. Something now exists in us, which had no being in our minds before. Nothing short of this comes up to the scriptural account of this matter. No excitations, no impulses, no aids, however forcible and great they are supposed to be, reach the intention of the holy Spirit, in those phrases, which he uses on this subject. Besides our corrupt nature is not a fit subject for heavenly excitations, nor is it possible to bring it in subjection to the obedience of Christ. The carnal mind can never become subject to the law of Christ. A bitter fountain will as soon send forth sweet streams, which all know is impossible. Regeneration doth not consist
in

in acts, but in the production of a principle disposed unto actions holy and well pleasing unto God, by *Jesus Christ*; and therefore this work is instantaneous and wrought on the mind at once."

"By conversion I understand, what may be called the *primary* actings of the regenerate principle. Before I proceed in discoursing on which, I would premise two things. One is, the human mind, as it seems to me, is one rational principle of operation. The *schools* have taught us, that there are three distinct powers of the human soul, *viz.* The understanding: The will; and the affections. They have done this for the sake of accuracy, in speaking of the distinct actions of our minds. I much question whether this is according to truth in philosophy, and I can't but apprehend, that it hath not been serviceably to the cause of truth in divinity, particularly, in treating on the subject now under consideration.

It seems to me, that our intelligent nature is one power, and not the subject of different and distinct powers, but capable of exerting itself, in various modes. In perception, willing, nilling, loving, hating, &c. The other thing I would premise is this: That grace is one spiritual principle of operation in the soul, and not, properly speaking, various and distinct habits seated in our mind; but able to exert itself after diverse ways. As, in spiritual perception, holy chusing and refusing, loving and delighting in spiritual things, in a spiritual manner, which are commonly spoken of as acts of so many different and distinct habits of Grace in our minds; but I think, that they all proceed from one principle, as their common root and spring. If this is true, those contests, which have arisen and been litigated between *learned* men, concerning grace as having one power of the mind only for its subject, and concerning the impropriety, of supposing, that the grace of faith is seated in two powers of the soul, *viz.* the understanding and the will: I say,

say, if this is true, those contests may soon be issued, and that it is not, I am humbly of opinion, neither philosophy, nor religion will prove."

It should have been observed to the reader, that by the REFORMED, or the *reformed church*, foreign writers mean all denominations of Protestants, except the Lutherans (with respect to whom they are called reformed) and some heretical sects that have sprung up among them, as the *Sacini*ans, *Arminians*, &c.

This publication would have been rendered more compleat by quotations from Turretine and the doings of the famous Synod of Dort, had not the publisher been disappointed about procuring these books.

N. B. The Synod of Dort mentioned by Van Maastricht, Le Blanc, &c. consisted of delegates from the whole Reformed Church, was called by the States of Holland in the reign of King James the First, to consider the Arminian heresy, which was condemned by that Synod.



E R R A T A.

Page 28. line 19. for *these* read *those*. P. 44. l. 19. after *confirms*, add *than destroys*. P. 53. l. 22. for *enabled* read *enobled*. P. 56. l. 6. for *pure* read *purser*. Ibid last line, for *their* read *the*. Before law read *the*. P. 81: l. 12. for *regeneration* read *generation*.

